

Friday, October 2, 2026

mint

| Think Ahead. Think Growth. |

mint primer

Why tax refunds matter for Indian apparel exports

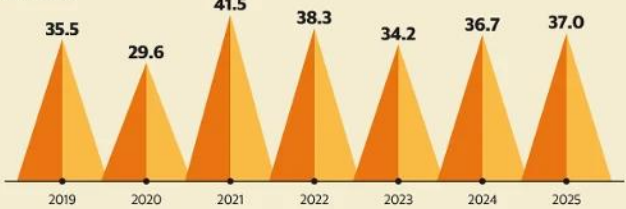
BY DHIRENDRA KUMAR

The Centre has extended the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL) scheme for apparel and made-up exporters by three months to 31 December, even as it works on a proposal to continue the scheme for another five years, as *Mint* reported on 28 September.

Hard recovery

The recovery of India's textile exports has been uneven since 2020, hinting at competitive pressure from lower-cost manufacturing destinations.

India's export of textiles and apparels (in \$ billion)



Source: DGCIS

mint

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

1 What is the RoSCTL scheme?

Introduced in March 2019, the RoSCTL refunds eligible state and central taxes, duties and levies embedded in exported apparel and made-ups that are not refunded through other mechanisms. The principle is straightforward: domestic taxes and levies incurred on goods meant for export should not remain embedded in their overseas selling price and make Indian products less competitive. The scheme is therefore different from a direct export subsidy. Its stated purpose is to remit eligible domestic taxes and levies that would otherwise remain embedded in export costs.

2 Who benefits from the scheme?

The scheme primarily covers exporters of apparel, garments and made-ups, with a significant share of beneficiaries being micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). According to the textile ministry, more than 15,400 exporters received rebates ranging from 1.7% to 8.2% under the scheme in fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26). Its reach matters because textile and garment manufacturing is spread across multiple clusters. The sector is also labour-intensive, providing direct employment to more than 45 million people, making export competitiveness relevant not only to foreign-exchange earnings but also to jobs.

3 Why is the extension significant?

The government has retained existing rates and guidelines until 31 December, ensuring that the scheme does not lapse while a longer-term decision is worked out. That short horizon is a concern for an industry in which orders are planned months in advance. Industry executives argue that the RoSCTL should have a longer policy horizon.

4 How much does the Centre spend on it?

Government spending stood at ₹9,176 crore in FY22, fell to ₹7,659 crore in FY23, and rose to ₹8,033 crore in FY24, ₹8,565 crore in FY25, and to ₹10,010 crore in FY26. For FY27, the allocation is ₹5,000 crore. The industry argues the scheme is important because Indian exporters should not carry domestic tax costs into overseas markets. With apparel imports from the US and European Union contracting, RoSCTL refunds help them stay competitive, said Prabhu Dhamodharan, convener, Indian Texpreneurs Federation (ITF).

5 Why does it matter for textile exports?

The government aims to raise textile exports to \$100 billion by 2030. India's apparel exports stood at \$35.49 billion in 2019, fell to \$29.61 billion in 2020, and rebounded to \$44.47 billion in 2021, according to government data. They then fell to \$38.31 billion in 2022 and \$34.23 billion in 2023, before recovering to \$36.71 billion in 2024 and \$36.95 billion in 2025. The uneven recovery points to continued competitive pressure as Indian producers compete with lower-cost manufacturing destinations.

QUICK EDIT

A steeper path ahead

Amid all the flux in the global economy, the finance ministry's economic review for September is reassuring but also sobering. Though it sees India's economy growing 7.3% in the July-September quarter, an enviably high rate, the momentum may be slowing. Domestic and external challenges abound, making it harder to hold that pace. The impact of weak monsoon rains on farm output, high oil import bills, inflation trends and globally hardening interest rates could all weigh on the economy. "India cannot afford to take its growth performance for granted," it said. Weaponization of supply chains and geopolitical polarization are intensifying in its analysis. Overall, its assessment has a cautious tone, which should keep policymakers on their toes. Monthly indicators of economic activity, thankfully, have held up well. September's purchasing managers' index reading for manufacturing was at 55.1, up from 52.8 in August, and the month's gross GST revenue mop-up of ₹2.04 trillion was 15% over last year's level. India's stock market, though, seems to have turned into a one-way street lately. It has been reacting disproportionately to bad news. When that might change is hard to bet on.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

When AI can process thousands of documents within moments, and when governments have access to real-time data, citizens expect quick solutions.

NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

He was addressing the centenary celebrations of the Union Public Service Commission.



INSIDE

Mark to Market | Manufacturing PMI's dead cat bounce >P4

Global | U.S. pressure campaign leaves Iranian tankers stranded in Asian waters >P8

Money | Tech wealth fuelled Bengaluru's luxury home boom. What now? >P11

Views | Why Gandhi's talisman should remain resonant >P12

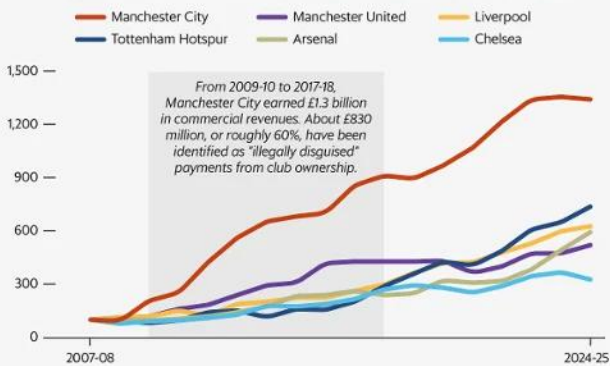
Business of Life | Destinations that offer luxury on a platter >P14

mint | DATA BITES

HOW DID MANCHESTER CITY'S REVENUES GROW?

Manchester City has been found guilty of "inflating" commercial revenues by an independent commission. Data shows after Abu Dhabi United Group bought the club in 2008, its financial and sporting fortunes skyrocketed over the next decade.

Relative movement in annual commercial revenues of big six football Premier League clubs (rebased, 2007-08=100)



Data: Anjishnu Das
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Deloitte Sports Business Group, annual club statements

m COLUMNS



INDIRA RAJARAMAN
THE LINDSEY GRAHAM
SANCTIONING RUSSIA AND
IRAN ACT IS A TRAVESTY >P13

Himanshu
EL NIÑO HAS
SPELT A TWIN
WHAMMY FOR THE
COUNTRY'S RURAL
ECONOMY >P12

Ajit
Ranade
HOW THE TATA
LEGACY EVOKES
GANDHI'S IDEA OF
TRUSTEESHIP >P12





DATA RECAP

THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

From the government setting a lower foodgrain production target for the ongoing crop year to deficient monsoon rainfall in two of every five districts in India, the weakness in the Indian stock market weighing on valuations across the board, Tamil Nadu being the sole leading state to increase its share of national factory output in 2024-25 and the continuing medal run of Indian chess—here is this week’s news in numbers.

FOOD SHOCK

India's foodgrain production (in million tonnes)



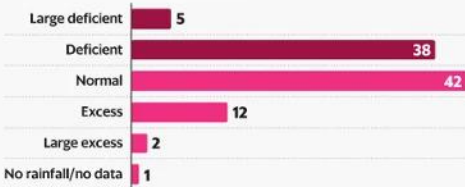
Data for 2025-26 are third advance estimates; 2026-27 figures are projections.
Source: Unified Portal for Agricultural Statistics; Media reports

THE GOVERNMENT has set a foodgrain production target of 373.93 million tonnes (mt) for the 2026-27 crop year, about 0.7% below the record output estimated for 2025-26. The lower target comes amid deficient monsoon rainfall during the kharif season and the threat of El Niño. Foodgrain output rose 7.7% in 2025-26 and 5.3% in 2024-25.

The lower target reflects subdued expectations for rice and maize output. Agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said crops had been damaged across about 611,000 hectares in Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Gujarat because of heavy rains, floods or droughts.

DEFICIENT RAINS

Share of India's districts by deviation from LPA (in %), during southwest monsoon, Jun-Sep 2026



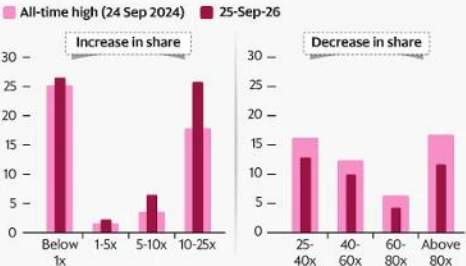
LPA: long-period average (1971 to 2020). Rainfall categories are based on deviation from normal; large excess ≥60%; excess 20% to 59%; normal -19% to +19%; deficient -20% to -59%; and large deficient -60% to -100%.

Source: India Meteorological Department

INDIA'S SOUTH-WEST monsoon ended at 87% of its long-period average (LPA), making it the 13th-weakest since 1901, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) data. The June-September monsoon began with rainfall 35.4% below normal in June, followed by a 1% surplus in July, a 16.3% shortfall in August and a 7.6% shortfall in September. India last recorded a below-normal monsoon in 2023, when rainfall was 95% of the LPA. The deficit was spread across the country, with 43% of India's 734 districts recording deficient rainfall. Among major agricultural states, Bihar, Punjab and Karnataka each recorded deficient rainfall in four of five districts.

SILVER LININGS

Share of BSE companies (in %) by price-to-earnings ratio range



Source: ACE Equity; Mint analysis

THE INDIAN stock market continued to weaken, with the benchmark BSE Sensex losing 2.7% during the trading week. The index is now down 16.5% from its all-time high. The correction has, however, pushed a larger share of stocks into lower valuation bands, as measured by their price-to-earnings (PE) multiples, according to a *Mint* analysis of 3,756 BSE-listed companies based on ACE Equity data.

The share of stocks trading at a PE multiple above 40 fell from 36% in September 2024 to 26%, while the share in the 10-25 PE band rose from 18% to 26%. While lower PE multiples can signal attractive valuations, they can also point to weaker earnings growth.

NUMBERS TALK

● **1%:** The increase in the minimum support price of wheat for the upcoming *rabi* marketing season. The highest increases were for safflower, at 10.3% and rapeseed and mustard, at 6.7% each.

● **103,000:** Houses sold across nine major cities in the July-September quarter, down 6% from a year ago, according to PropEquity. Only Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Navi Mumbai recorded growth.

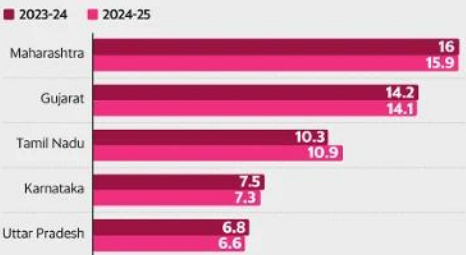
● **16:** Indian men who joined the boards of S&P 500 companies this year, according to ISS-Corporate and data provider Equilar. Only white men and women secured a higher number of board seats.

● **\$6 trillion:** Annual global revenue the artificial intelligence (AI) market will need to generate by 2031 to justify the capital being deployed to build AI infrastructure, according to Bain & Co.

● **₹645 crore:** What ITC paid to raise its stake in Sproutlife Foods, which owns nutrition and healthy foods brand Yoga Bar, from 47.5% to 100%. ITC first invested in Sproutlife in May 2023.

MANUFACTURING STATE

Top five states by share of manufacturing GVA (in %)



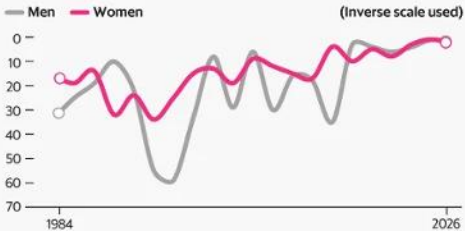
Source: Annual Survey of Industries

THE NUMBER of registered factories in operation in India increased 2.6% year-on-year in 2024-25, while employment in them rose 7.3% to 16.6 million, according to the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) 2024-25, released by the statistics ministry.

Tamil Nadu accounted for the largest share of manufacturing employment at 15%, followed by Maharashtra at 13.1%, Gujarat at 13%, Uttar Pradesh at 8.7% and Haryana at 6.4%. Gross value added (GVA) by factories increased 9.6%. Among the five states with the largest GVA, four saw their share of national factory GVA decline. Tamil Nadu was the exception: its share rose from 10.3% in 2023-24 to 10.9% in 2024-25.

MEDAL RUN

India's rank in Chess Olympiad over the years



Data since 1984, when Viswanathan Anand made his debut at the Chess Olympiad.

Source: olimpbase.org

INDIA'S MEN'S and women's chess teams finished among the medals at the recently concluded Chess Olympiad in Samarkand, Uzbekistan, but could not defend their titles. The men finished second and the women third, with Uzbekistan A winning the men's competition and China the women's.

India also won the title of best overall side and individual medals for six of its 10 players, including a gold for Savitha Shri. It was the sixth consecutive time that the Indian men finished in the Olympiad's top 10, while the women extended their top-10 run to five.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

TVS ties deepen



A company owned by N. Chandrasekaran's family is pursuing a ₹330-crore industrial park in Karnataka for TVS Motor. The ties have raised questions over disclosure and potential conflicts, especially after TVS chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan backed Chandrasekaran's third term.

Air India's double act



T. W. Gebremariam has inherited an airline group bleeding cash, with Air India and Air India Express losing ₹22,238 crore in FY26. AIX is growing rapidly but remains financially stretched, even as Tata shifts more routes and aircraft its way. Can Gebremariam make the two-airline model work?

Why the Mistrys want out



The SP Group's ₹25,000-crore offer to sell part of its Tata Sons stake fell flat, with the board backing the extension for N. Chandrasekaran and moving towards a listing. For the Mistrys, a heavily leveraged group and a prized but illiquid stake have made Tata Sons' future valuation more urgent.

Friday, October 2, 2026

mint

livemint.com



T20: when club or country turns into a googly ▶ P10



Anup Bagchi named HDFC Bank chief for three years ▶ P5

SENSEX 71,909.69 ↓ 570.59

NIFTY 22,421.95 ↓ 198.50

DOLLAR ₹96.32 ↓ ₹0.49

EURO ₹108.53 ↑ ₹0.31

OIL \$99.74 ↑ \$2.08

POUND ₹127.13 ↑ ₹0.12

Healthy realty units may gain IBC shield

IBBI set to tweak rules to allow CoC shield solvent projects

Banikinkar Pattanayak
banikinkar.pattanayak@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Homebuyers in healthy real estate projects may soon be spared the fallout when their developer defaults on another project. The insolvency watchdog is set to tweak regulations to allow the committee of creditors (CoC) to recommend keeping solvent projects out of bankruptcy proceedings, even when the developer as a whole enters the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP), two people in the know said.

The proposal, however, must be backed by a 66% vote of the CoC and approved by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) for it to take effect, the people told *Mint*.

The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI), which regulates the regime under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), had deliberated on the proposal at its last board meeting held late August, and the new regulations would be notified shortly, they said.

The development caps months of discussions over how a project-wise insolvency plan will be implemented.

Currently, once a builder is



REAL TEST

MOVE needs 66% CoC approval and NCLT clearance

- IBBI had deliberated on the proposal at its board meet in August
- IBBI yet to count projects, homebuyers likely to benefit

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

admitted into the CIRP, all its projects come under insolvency proceedings. This hurts the interests of buyers living in finished or solvent projects, who then face disruption in maintenance and uncertainties in registration because the same developer defaulted elsewhere.

The development assumes sig-

nificance given that real estate accounts for 22% of insolvency cases undergoing resolution in India, and is the second-biggest sector after manufacturing, which makes up for 36%.

Several real estate firms—such as

UPI transaction volumes, value fall after MDR news

Anshika Kayastha
anshika.kayastha@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Transactions on the unified payments interface (UPI) platform dipped in September after the government announced reintroduction of a merchant discount rate (MDR) on select transactions from 15 October, with a sharper decline in the second half pointing to some caution among customers and merchants ahead of the new fee.

The UPI platform processed 24.07 billion transactions in September, down 1.8% from August. The value of transactions fell 1.5% to ₹29.4 lakh crore, according to data from the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), which operates the UPI platform.

Importantly, NPCI's daily data shows a dip in both volumes and value in month's second half, after the 15 September MDR announcement.

Daily transaction volumes ranged between 792 million and 859 million in the first half of September, before falling to between 748 million and 810 million in the second. The value of transactions declined to between ₹73,615 crore and ₹99,645 crore, from ₹79,166



UPI processed 24.07 billion transactions in September.

crore to ₹1.3 trillion in the first half, with the last day of the month as an outlier with transactions of ₹1.1 trillion.

Some of this decline reflects normal seasonal patterns rather than MDR-driven caution: UPI transactions typically slow in a month's latter half, and volumes and values also tend to run lower in 30-day months compared with 31-day months. A decline beyond these historical patterns, however, could signal greater caution among users.

JSW beats Tata, Leyland to win 1,200 e-bus tender

Ayaan Kartik & Manas Pimpalkhare
NEW DELHI

Sajjan Jindal-owned JSW Group has raced ahead of established players Tata Motors and Ashok Leyland to win its first government order for electric buses, emerging as the lowest bidder for about 1,200 units in a 4,054-bus tender, according to two executives in the know.

The order, under the PM-eBus Sewa scheme, gives JSW a sizeable foothold in a market dominated by legacy bus makers and newer players such as Eka Mobility and PMI Electro Mobility.

The order win will boost the Jindal conglomerate's aggressive automobile push. The group had, in 2024, set up its commercial-vehicle entity, JSW Greentech, a subsidiary of Sajjan Jindal family-owned JSW Green Mobility.

While the tender value is not known, electric buses in such tenders are typically priced about ₹1-1.25 crore each. Operators generally procure these from manufacturers and run them for state transport units that pay on a

DON'T MISS

India can't rest on growth laurels: finance ministry

India's resilience to external shocks is being tested by a tougher global fight for capital, with unsettled trade ties with the US, AI boom and a manufacturing push in developed economies all threatening to weigh on inflows, the finance ministry said. >P2

GST mop-up stays above ₹2 trillion for third month

India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections rose 14.7% in September to ₹2.04 trillion from ₹1.77 trillion a year earlier, with the headline growth driven largely by a sharper rise in tax collected on imports, which increased nearly 26%. >P2

New advisory firms target startups, private equity funds

A fresh crop of advisory firms has sprung up in India amid intensifying competition in the sector and the changing nature of work in consultancy services. These mid-tier consulting companies have chalked out a different strategy. >P3

Accenture sees higher AI spend by clients as token costs fall

Accenture PLC expects companies to spend more on automation tools as the costs of deploying them reduce, even as it expects revenue deflation to persist for technology services firms. The management's upbeat tone was backed by its results. >P6

Thank You

Our Customers

for your continued trust and support

Our Stakeholders

for your guidance and partnership

Our Employees

for your dedication and commitment

₹30 LAKH CRORE+

TOTAL GLOBAL BUSINESS

(Provisional Figures as on 30-09-2026)

We express our profound gratitude to our esteemed customers, stakeholders and well-wishers for their valuable support.

1 Bank Number

1800 1030

24x7

www.canarabank.bank.in

केनरा बैंक

Canara Bank

A Government of India Undertaking

Together We Can



Centre has halved permissible stock to 1,000 quintals, holding period to 15 days. REUTERS

Govt cuts sugar stock limit to curb hoarding for festivals

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The government has tightened sugar stockholding norms for dealers ahead of the festive season, halving the permissible stock to 1,000 quintals and the holding period to 15 days, in a bid to curb hoarding and ensure adequate supplies to consumers during the peak festive season beginning 11 October.

The revised norms will take effect from 15 October and stay in force till 30 November, the ministry of consumer affairs, food and public distribution said in a statement on Thursday. Dealers will not be allowed to hold sugar for more than 15 days from the date of receipt or hold more than 1,000 quintals of stock at any location at any given time, it said. The move aims to keep sugar prices in check at a time when demand typically rises during festival season.

Retail sugar prices stood at ₹55.62 per kg on 1 October, about 20% higher than a year earlier. However, prices have corrected sharply from their August peak, falling 11.7% from ₹62.96 per kg a month earlier.

However, a higher stockholding limit of 2,000 quintals has been allowed in Kolkata and its extended metropolitan areas and Assam, taking into account the logistical requirements of supplying sugar to eastern and north-eastern India and the seasonal surge in demand during Durga Puja.

"Kolkata sources sugar from Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka and supplies it to the eastern part of the country, including the North-Eastern region," the ministry said, explaining the higher limit for the region. The additional allowance for Assam takes into account geographical constraints and transportation logistics. The move comes at the beginning of the new sugar season on 1 October, with the government seeking to prevent the accumulation of stocks in the distribution chain and discourage speculative trading amid peaking demand.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

India cannot rest on growth laurels: finance ministry

India faces a stiff challenge in drawing capital flows amid external turmoil, says economic review

Banikinkar Pattanayak
banikinkar.pattanayak@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's resilience to external shocks is being tested by a tougher global fight for capital, with unsettled trade ties with the US, the investment boom around artificial intelligence (AI) and a manufacturing push in developed economies all threatening to weigh on inflows, the finance ministry said on Thursday.

The country faces a "stiff challenge" in drawing capital flows amid external turmoil, like other developing economies, while short-term pressure on the rupee remains. The economy has shown it can absorb shocks, the ministry said, but the country cannot afford to lower its guard or rest on its post-pandemic growth laurels.

Economic growth, therefore, has to be "earned every quarter", the ministry said in its economic review for September, highlighting the challenge for policymakers.

India has remained the world's fastest-growing major economy since fiscal year 2022 (FY22), and most analysts expect it to expand 6.8-7% this fiscal year after a stronger-than-expected 7.8% growth in the June quarter.

The June quarter's growth momentum has extended into the second quarter of FY27, "though at a more measured pace".



Economic growth has to be 'earned every quarter', the finance ministry said in its economic review for September. MINT

"Our nowcasting measure, unveiled in the Economic Survey earlier this year, anticipates a real GDP growth rate of 7.3% in the fiscal second quarter," the ministry said.

The ministry expects net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows to rebound this fiscal year through March 2027, while stressing the economy's resilience to external shocks. Between April and July, net FDI rose 38% from a year earlier to \$13.4 billion, while gross inflows stood at \$43.9 billion.

The report pointed to a global headwinds. Oil prices surged in September following a fresh flare-up in the West

Asia conflict, while global bond yields have also risen.

India's bond yield has risen at a much slower pace, the ministry said, but the resulting lower risk premium is putting pressure on the rupee. Still, "there is every possibility that, over the medium term, investors would appreciate the fundamental reasons behind the lower risk premium on Indian debt".

The yield on the 10-year US treasury papers has jumped 52 basis points in the past one month to 5.32%, while that on the Indian government securities of the same tenor has risen 25 bps to 7.21%.

The ministry identified three short-term pressures on India's ability to attract capital.

First, trade relations with the US remain unsettled after Washington adopted a law in late September empowering the President to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries buying Russian crude oil.

Second, the global AI investment cycle continues to channel capital across borders. "At the same time, the AI bubble has not begun its inevitable meaningful deflation. The AI story continues to drive capital investment and capital flows across borders," the report said. Third, developed economies are competing to secure investments for renewed manufacturing ambitions amid the increasing weaponization of global supply chains.

The ministry pointed to several signs that domestic growth remains resilient. Merchandise and services exports may reach a record \$1 trillion this fiscal year, as they have already crossed \$400 billion in the first five months of FY27.

"That is a very strong confirmation that India's trade agreements are providing impetus to India's exports. It can only get better from here, with more trade agreements on the anvil," it said. The trade deficit narrowed in August, helped by a 26.1% jump in goods exports.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

GST mop-up stays above ₹2 trillion for third month

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections rose 14.7% in September to ₹2.04 trillion from ₹1.77 trillion a year earlier, with the headline growth driven largely by a sharper rise in tax collected on imports, which increased nearly 26%, according to provisional data released by the finance ministry on Thursday.

September was the third month this fiscal year in which collections crossed the ₹2 trillion mark, but were below the ₹2.11 trillion collected in July, when the monthly mop-up crossed ₹2 trillion for the second time. July's collection was the second-highest since GST was introduced in July 2017, after the record ₹2.43 trillion collected in April 2026.

The September numbers come ahead of the 57th GST Council meeting on 7 October in New Delhi. While the council's agenda has not yet been made public, discussions are likely to include a review of GST on merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, with a new MDR levied slated to take effect from 15 October. The meeting could also provide an opportunity to review the implementation of rate rationalization and take up outstanding issues under the indirect tax regime, Mint reported on 28 August.



Gross GST collections were ₹1.77 trillion a year ago. MINT

Gross domestic GST revenue rose 10.1% to ₹1.38 trillion in September from ₹1.25 trillion a year earlier.

GST collected on imports jumped 25.9% to ₹65,525 crore. The rise is in line with the trend seen earlier in the fiscal.

According to a Crisil Ratings analysis published on 22 September, IGST collections from imports grew nearly 30% in the five months through August, aided by imports of electronics, machinery, gold, fertilisers and other key goods. Crisil also said elevated commodity prices, rupee depreciation and stable import volumes were supporting import-linked IGST collections.

In September, domestic GST revenue increased by ₹12,662 crore over the year, while GST revenue from imports rose by ₹13,494 crore.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

CAFE-III offers 3-year cushion to self-attest fuel efficiency tech

Manas Pimpalkhare & Ayaan Kartik

NEW DELHI

India's carmakers will get three years to self-certify a dozen fuel-saving technologies under the Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE) III rules, which will kick in on 1 April, helping them meet the tighter efficiency targets. During this period, the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) will develop certification methods for these technologies, which will become mandatory from FY31.

CAFE-III rules were notified amid a deep divide in the world's third largest automobile market by sales volume, as a September 2025 draft of these norms had created a special carve-out for cars weighing under 909kg, which was widely seen benefiting market leader Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. The issue is now resolved as the overall targets for light cars have been eased in the final norms.

After one year of consulta-



Carmakers can self-certify a dozen fuel-saving technologies. MINT

tions, the final norms were notified by the ministry of power on Wednesday, setting a 16% fuel efficiency improvement target for India's carmakers over the next five years.

As per the rules, MoRTH will develop the certification requirements during the first three-year CAFE-III block, during which carmakers will self-certify these products and claim a 9g CO₂/km incentive every year, equal to a fuel efficiency relaxation equalling 0.3795 litres/100km benefit

on the target every year.

Fuel efficiency targets are set for the average fuel efficiency of a carmaker's annual sales. They are measured in terms of litres of fuel consumed for covering 100km. The math for how much fuel a vehicle consumes begins with its tailpipe emissions (grams of carbon dioxide emitted per km), that's converted into fuel used per 100km.

Carmakers need to ensure their fleets have an average efficiency of 3.9960 litres/100km in FY28, followed by 3.8600 litres in FY29, 3.7585 in FY30, 3.5313 in FY31 and 3.3273 in FY32. They will have to comply with requirements that MoRTH will create for these 12 technologies in the second block, covering FY31 and FY32.

Queries emailed to BEE, the ministries of road transport, power, and heavy industries, and carmakers Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors, Hyundai, and M&M remained unanswered.

manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Centre fixes guardrails ahead of UPI fee

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

As India's new fee on UPI merchant transactions kicks in on 15 October, the government is preparing to ensure the cost does not unfairly land on consumers. The department of consumer affairs is strengthening the National Consumer Helpline (NCH) to handle complaints under the new merchant discount rate (MDR) framework and clarify which UPI payments must remain free, two government officials said.

The department, the custodian of consumer rights, will support the finance ministry in resolving complaints and grievances received through the consumer helpline, they said. The department has strengthened the helpline to handle such complaints, having already managed a similar flow post rationalization of goods and services tax rates last September.

"Since the NCH serves as a pre-litigation consumer grievance redressal mechanism, the department is putting in place a detailed set of dos and don'ts to guide consumers on the



The department of consumer affairs is strengthening the National Consumer Helpline to handle MDR-related complaints. ISTOCKPHOTO

new framework," said the first of the two people cited above. "It is also training call-centre executives to respond to consumer queries and grievances with accurate and relevant information."

"As clearly stated by the finance ministry, person-to-person (P2P) UPI transactions will remain completely free, while a 0.4% MDR will apply only to specified person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions of above ₹2,000. Transactions of up to ₹2,000 will also remain free," said the second person.

"If consumers register complaints with the NCH against merchants for imposing charges in violation of these provisions, the complaints will be examined under the Consumer Protection Act and necessary action will be taken," the person said.

To be sure, for P2M UPI transactions of ₹75,000 and

above, the MDR is capped at ₹300 per transaction. The standard MDR is 0.4%, but the cap means the charge does not keep increasing beyond ₹300.

The helpline is a channel for consumers to seek clarifications and redressal. After the GST rationalization move, it got 3,981 queries and grievances in about two weeks of implementation. Of these, 69% were grievances, while 31% were queries.

Queries will be answered immediately, while for grievances, the consumer affairs department will examine whether they can be addressed under the Consumer Protection Act.

Complaints that fall under the purview of the finance ministry will be forwarded to the concerned department for appropriate action, the officials said.

Queries sent to the spokespersons of the consumer affairs department, the finance ministry and the department of financial services secretary remained unanswered until press time.

manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

MINT SHORTS

Power demand dips, pushes exchange prices to near zero

New Delhi: Heavy rains and a late-month dip in demand pushed power prices on exchanges to near-zero in several trading blocks (of 15 minutes each) in the last week of September, Indian Energy Exchange data shows. On 26 and 27 September, prices on the real-time platform were at or below 10 paise a unit for 26 and 18 trading blocks, respectively. RITURAJ BARUAH

FSSAI suspends licences of Shivam Agro, TCF Chocolates

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority

of India (FSSAI) has suspended licences of Shivam Agro and TCF Chocolates & Gifts Pvt. Ltd "following serious food safety violations identified during inspection". The action reinforces the importance of food safety, hygiene and regulatory compliance, the regulator said in a social media post. The companies were directed to cease all food business activities during the suspension period. PTI

Oil refiners change tactics and hire ships to cross Hormuz

Indian oil refiners are hiring tankers to sail through the Strait of Hormuz to pick up crude from within the Persian Gulf, a change of tactics to help them cut costs and secure their supply chains. Processors have issued tenders and are negotiating with shipping lines, people familiar with the efforts said. Indian refiners have avoided sending their own tankers through Hormuz since early in the US-Iran war owing to the risk of attacks. BLOOMBERG

Goyal, Greer hold talks on India-US interim trade deal



Milwaukee: Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday that he met United States trade representative Jamieson Greer and discussed steps for early conclusion of the India-US bilateral trade agreement. Goyal met Greer on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting, and was also to meet Canada's trade minister for non-US trade, Maninder Sidhu. REUTERS

India steps up palm oil buying as tax cut spurs restocking

India is snapping up palm oil after New Delhi slashed import duties, prompting refiners to replenish depleted inventories ahead of the festival season. The buying spree could provide a fresh boost to the global palm market as supplies at top producers Indonesia and Malaysia remain ample. BLOOMBERG

RBI forex swaps lets firms tap dollar funding at lower cost

Mumbai: Billions of dollars of forex swaps by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) have shifted the economics of cross-currency funding for Indian firms, creating an opportunity to access dollar funding at a relatively lower cost. RBI has been draining surplus liquidity in the banking system through dollar-rupee swaps. REUTERS

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to [feedback@livemint.com](#).

It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about Mint's journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to [asktheditor@livemint.com](#)

Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at [www.livemint.com](#)

New advisory firms target startups, private equity funds

The founders of these new firms cut their teeth in established audit and advisory firms

Devina Sengupta
devina.sengupta@livemint.com
MUMBAI

A fresh crop of advisory firms has sprung up in India amid intensifying competition in the sector and the changing nature of work in consultancy services. Squeezed between the established Big Four and management strategy consulting companies, these mid-tier consulting companies have chalked out a different strategy—offering specialized services to startups and private equity and venture capital firms that are more likely to tap the new cohort. The founders of this new set of consulting companies cut their teeth in the established audit and advisory firms, but unlike their larger competitors, they are focussed on offering a select bouquet of services such as managing family offices, risk advisory, and planning initial public offerings (IPOs) instead of providing the gamut of services from IT to audits and consulting. “The consulting sector grows at almost twice the rate at which GDP of a country does and therefore there is a lot of work coming in for the newer players as well,” said Jamil Khatri, co-founder and chief of Unicus Consultech. Khatri led the assurance practice of KPMG and quit to start Unicus in 2022. He said Unicus differentiates itself by specializing in IPO-readiness, finance transformation, artificial intelligence and risk. “While legacy companies may have some bias for larger brands, startups, PE and VC firms are keen to work with newer consulting companies like us. We are 800 employees with 80 partners, many of whom are from the Big Four,” Khatri said. In audit and advisory parlance, the Big Four are EY, KPMG, Deloitte and PwC, firms that were predominantly



Competition in the consulting sector is getting stiffer. ISTOCKPHOTO

audit companies but expanded over the years into advisory services. Armed with thousands of partners, these giants together employ 2,00,000 people. They often move into the lanes of management consulting companies such as Kearney, Bain & Co, McKinsey their own portfolios, the opportunity of acquiring equity in the new company and more independence. The calling card of the new ventures includes a more agile workplace where there is little hierarchy and decision-making lies largely in the hands of the partners.

MARKET SHIFT			
THE consulting sector grows at almost twice the rate at which GDP of a country does	IN audit and advisory parlance, the Big Four are EY, KPMG, Deloitte and PwC	GLOBAL wars, digitalization, tariffs and AI are reshaping advisory firms' offerings	WHILE boutique consulting firms are getting aggressive, established ones are making adjustments

& Co., and Boston Consulting Group, which do not work on audits and focus on strategic consulting. This cohort runs smaller teams of a few hundred only. According to executives, the newer crop of consulting companies picks up partners from larger firms, luring them with prospects of building “We manage to hire without a significant raise but what we offer additionally is equity, which can remain invested in the company even when the partner leaves,” Khatri said. A senior headhunter at one of India's top three search firms said the demand for consultants is on the rise as clients

want specialized services which some of the advisory firms offer. For the newer lot, the role of consultants has changed in many ways since the pandemic. Global wars, businesses going digital, a hazy vision of business cycles given the tariff wars and geopolitical strains along with the impact of artificial intelligence have led advisory firms to rejig their offerings to clients. “Clients want clear, focused advice—with their needs at the centre. At Transaction Square, we partner with them to execute complex decisions across restructuring, family offices and M&A,” said Girish Vanvari, founder of Transaction Square. Vanvari was national leader for tax at KPMG before he started his company in 2018. Of the other founders, Amol Khanna and Chirag Shah came from KPMG while Saloni Khandelwal was from PwC. Some clients may need specialists instead of a large brand that bills higher and this is where boutique consulting firms come into play. “Our SAP practice has nearly doubled in recent years, making it a key growth area for us, alongside technology transformation, cybersecurity and privacy,” said Sachin Tayal, managing director, Protiviti Member Firm for India, referring to support services for the enterprise software. While boutique consulting firms are getting aggressive, the established ones are going through their own adjustments. PwC India struck a joint venture with PwC US Advisory, prompting rivals to reassess ties with their own offshore units. Competition in the consulting sector is getting stiffer as more entities start testing the waters. *Mint* reported in September that Temasek-backed upGrad is entering B2B advisory services as it broadens its portfolio ahead of a planned 2027 listing. For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Google's Gemini 4 faces doubts over coding skills

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Alphabet Inc.'s Google has begun rolling out Gemini 4 Argon, its long-awaited flagship artificial intelligence model, but the company is grappling with internal scepticism over how well it performs in key areas, such as coding. Google unveiled the model Wednesday to a small group of trusted cybersecurity partners and said it will expand access after additional testing, starting with paid subscribers. The company said Gemini 4 posted leading scores on several benchmark tests, including beating OpenAI's Astra model on one that measures security skills. But some insiders say those metrics don't tell the whole story. While Gemini 4 has performed well on benchmarks widely used to gauge model efficacy, it does less well when employees actually put it to work, according to people with direct access to the effort. The model struggles to handle certain coding tasks, said the people, who requested anonymity to discuss an internal matter. Alphabet shares rose about 1.7% in extended trading after the company's announcement. Late in regular trading, they pared Wednesday's earlier gains after Bloomberg reported employee scepticism about the model. Google has laboured recently to develop models that can compete with OpenAI and Anthropic PBC. The company had planned to release a different version in June, dubbed Gemini 3.5 Pro, but abandoned the effort, the people



Some employees believe Anthropic's Fable and OpenAI's Astra models are improving at a faster rate than Gemini. AFP

ple said. Google said it would be inaccurate to say that Gemini 4 is underperforming in areas such as coding. The company referred Bloomberg back to comments made last week by Koray Kavukcuoglu, the head of Google DeepMind who said he was encouraged by the model's performance. “I have the utmost trust in the team,” Kavukcuoglu said at a conference hosted by tech news site The Information. “In my mind, it's a certainty that we are always gonna be at the frontier.” There is a spectrum of opinion inside Google. Some employees believe Anthropic's Fable and OpenAI's Astra models are improving at a faster rate than Gemini. These people believe that Gemini 4—even at its best—will still lag behind those models in some areas. Other employees believe the coming version has caught up with the leading AI labs. A Google employee familiar with model development said there is “large consensus” internally at the company that Gemini 4 is at the frontier. This person said the company had conducted rigorous tests of the models and denied that they struggle with messy, real-world coding tasks. Google badly needs Gemini 4 to succeed. Versions of the model underpin nearly every product the company sells, from the AI answers atop Search, Google's main profit engine, to Maps, Gmail and Chrome. Each of those products has more than a billion users, a distribution advantage some of the company's rivals lack. But OpenAI and Anthropic are increasingly moving beyond selling models to building products of their own, including coding agents. Failing to deliver a cutting-edge model could give Google's competitors more time to convince consumers, developers and businesses that the future of search and software should run on their platforms instead. In response to questions from Bloomberg, Google said that even though its last Pro model was released in February, the company has since seen growth in its AI products, including the enterprise version of Gemini as well as its consumer chatbot app and AI Mode in Google Search, the last two of which have crossed 1 billion users.

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission
6th Floor, GIFT ONE, Road 5C, Zone 5, GIFT City,
Dist.: Gandhinagar, Gujarat-382050.
(O) 079 23602000, (F) 079 23602054/55
e-mail-gerc@gercin.org Website: www.gercin.org

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RFP) FROM ELIGIBLE CONSULTANT
Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission (GERC) has issued a Request for Proposals (RFP) from competent/eligible consulting firms to provide consultancy support in scrutiny, review, approval and monitoring Capital Investment Plan and related matters.
For more details, please visit 'Latest News' at <https://gercin.org/news-category>. The last date for receiving proposal is **26.10.2026**. For future announcement, if any, in this regard, please keep referring to the above website.
Sd/-
Ranjeeth Kumar J., IAS
Secretary, GERC
Gift City, Gandhinagar
30/09/2026

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

NO. JDA/EST./ACTT./2026-27/D-1212 Date : 28.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-BID
NIB No.: DC(Admn.)-04/2026-27
Online Bids are invited for Providing service of Various Types Like Labourers (Supervisor Highly Skilled) security Men (Skilled), Unskilled Labour Services. estimated yearly cost one year of which is Rs. 26.00 Crore. **(UBN No.: JDA2627SLOB00334)** The last date for applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 05:00 PM of 21.10.2026. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in
To participate in the bid, bidder has to be
1. Registered on JDA website www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
2. Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10997 Deputy Commissioner (Admn.)

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

NO. F.6(444332)JDA/G.Store/Scanning Work/2026/D-329 Dated : 28-09-2026

NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No.: JDA/G.Store/18/2026-27
Online Bids are invited For "Scanning Work" up-to 21.10.2026 Till 6:00 PM. Estimated cost of Work is **Rs.1,50,00,000/- (One Crore fifty Lacs Only)**. The last date for Applying for Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is 21.10.2026 by 06.00 PM. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document Available on jda.rajasthan.gov.in www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. **(UBN No.: JDA2627WSRC00338)**
To participate in the bid, bidder has to be
1. Registered on JDA website jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
2. Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10999 Deputy Commissioner (Store)

lounge

LIVING WITH BOOKS
Lounge meets some uncommon readers to understand how reading, buying, losing and returning to books has shaped their lives

THINK: Stop policing school lunch boxes

TASTE: What Michelin guides could bring to India

TRAVEL: The little-known mangroves of Honnavar

CULTURE: Still searching for Zahir Raihan

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of **HT TWTW** A quiz on the week's development.
THE WEEK THAT WAS
FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		BSE 150 MidCap		BSE 250 SmallCap	
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
71,909.70	-0.79	22,421.95	-0.88	21,857.75	-0.97	68,981.35	-1.10	23,516.50	-0.92	15,997.57	-0.99	6,909.40	-1.23
PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN
72,480.29	72,192.89	22,620.45	22,543.70	22,072.10	22,005.00	69,746.95	69,531.05	23,734.70	23,655.50	16,156.98	16,117.04	6,995.30	6,977.09
HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW
72,572.90	71,292.80	22,610.60	22,217.30	22,046.80	21,623.25	69,683.90	68,110.50	23,722.00	23,286.70	16,140.86	15,788.24	6,977.29	6,818.23

Mfg PMI's dead cat bounce

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha.j@livemint.com

Business momentum in India's manufacturing sector has taken a U-turn. The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) rose to a seven-month high of 55.1 in September after hitting a five-year low of 52.8 in August. Faster increases in new orders and output aided recovery and supported job creation. Higher demand for electronic, food, pharmaceutical and textile products drove a sharper increase in new business intakes.

Indian manufacturers upgraded their output forecasts. The PMI sub-index gauging business confidence rose to a four-month high in September. This optimism was underpinned by new enquiries in the pipeline and expectations that demand conditions will remain favourable, said the PMI survey. In line with future sales expectations, companies increased stocks. Holdings of finished products rose for the third month in a row in September

One month wonder?

India's manufacturing PMI hit a seven-month high in September, driving increased confidence among firms.



and at the second-fastest pace in 11-and-a-half years.

But this may well be a one-month wonder. The PMI average for July-September stood at 53.8, its lowest since the same period in 2021. With Brent crude oil at \$98 per barrel levels and food inflation set to pinch harder, the road ahead for the

Indian economy is bumpy.

"The macro-outlook is likely to become more challenging in Q3FY27, as the weak and uneven monsoon, alongside rising El Niño risks, could feed into food prices," said Motilal Oswal Financial Services on 25 September.

High input costs are adding pres-

sure across transportation, energy and manufacturing activities. In August, inflation measured via the wholesale price index (WPI) surged to 10%. Inflation measured via the consumer price index (CPI) or retail inflation rose to 4.82% with food inflation at 5.95%. "The gap between WPI and CPI inflation will remain elevated as long as the West Asia crisis persists," said Gaura Sen Gupta, chief economist, IDFC First Bank. A widening gap between these metrics indicates the weak pricing power of businesses.

The odds of an interest rate hike by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on 7 October, are rising. RBI has maintained a pause on interest rates in 2026. Morgan Stanley expects RBI to begin hiking in October against its prior expectation of December, and tighten a cumulative 100 basis points (bps) through four straight 25 bps hikes, taking the terminal policy rate to 6.25% by April 2027. Higher

food prices, tighter liquidity and elevated borrowing costs would dent customers' purchasing power, thus weighing on credit-sensitive sectors and consumption. For manufacturers, there is little room to raise prices and protect margins.

The PMI survey showed that higher prices for electronic components, pharma items and steel pushed up overall cost burdens in September. The rate of input cost inflation accelerated from August, but remained below its long-run average.

Selling prices also increased at a quicker pace, but the increase was modest. "In Q1FY27, companies were able to pass on some of the rise in input costs to consumers which supported profit growth. The longer the supply-shock persists, companies will continue to pass on input cost pressures to consumers and after a point, sales volume growth could moderate," Sen Gupta added.

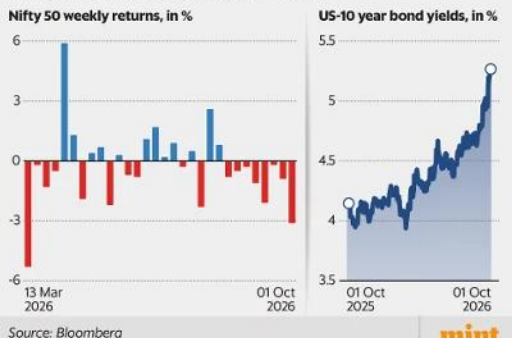
DEMAND BOOST

THE PMI sub-index gauging business confidence rose to a four-month high in September

STRONG demand for electronics, food, pharma and textiles drove higher new business intakes

Stock slop

Rising bond yields deepen equity losses.



Eight-week slide puts focus on RBI

Mayur Bhalerao

mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Cheaper oil failed to bring much comfort for Indian equities as the markets slid for the eighth consecutive week. Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001 in a holiday-truncated week, with markets closed on Friday for Gandhi Jayanti. On Thursday, it fell 0.88% to 22,421.95, while the Sensex declined 0.79% to 71,909.69.

Their weekly losses stood at 3.11% and 2.69%, respectively, with the Nifty posting its sharpest weekly decline since the week ended 13 March 2026. The retreat has sharpened a question: is a recovery in sight?

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at I29 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said elevated oil prices, rupee weakness and higher US bond yields were driving foreign outflows. Foreign portfolio investors sold a net ₹35,861 crore of equities in September, with ₹19,273 crore—53.7% of the monthly outflow—withdrawn in the final seven trading sessions. Selling continued on Thursday, with another ₹9,232 crore offloaded.

The US 10-year Treasury

yield climbed to around 5.3%, its highest since June 2007, while India's benchmark government bond yield hovered near 7.20%. Crude's retreat to about \$96.30 a barrel offered relief, but proved insufficient to reverse market sentiment.

On earnings trajectory, V.K. Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist, Geojit Investments Ltd notes that if crude prices remain elevated for long, economic growth and corporate earnings will be impacted.

"The market is concerned about this. In this context, 5.2% yield from the US 10-year bond becomes very attractive for FPIs," he added.

That assessment also faces a test at the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee meeting on 5-7 October.

September-quarter results will offer another test, beginning with Tata Consultancy Services on 8 October.

India also lagged most markets in the global snapshot. Only Indonesia's Jakarta Composite, down 3.72%, fell more than the Nifty. France's CAC 40 and South Korea's KRX100 lost 2.18% and 2.04%, respectively.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Can tech fix ICICI Lombard's underwriting equation?

Ananya Roy
feedback@livemint.com

ICICI Lombard General Insurance Co.'s Digital Day meet on Tuesday has raised hopes of improving the insurer's profits from its recent slump. The stock gained 4% the next day.

The management showcased how tech is moving from a back-office enabler to being integrated across the entire business, from underwriting, risk management and pricing to distribution, claims and servicing.

The digital share of its servicing has expanded from

20% in FY23 to 47% in FY26, and further to 71% in Q1FY27, aiming for 90% by FY29. Digital servicing costs 90% less than manual servicing. The insurer's share of digital sourcing is also set to expand from 6% to 15%, which, along with the shrinkage in product launch time (6 months versus 4 weeks), can bring in 3-5% of gross written premium from new launches by FY29.

The digital leap is expected to translate into 100-200 basis points higher growth versus the industry, a sustained 10+ percentage point advantage in combined ratio, and 17-20% return on equity

Core drag

ICICI Lombard has made profits despite losses in its core underwriting business.



(RoE). Combined ratio measures underwriting profitability; it is the ratio of claims paid and other operating expenses

to premiums earned.

The timing is important, as its stock has fallen 13% since Q1FY27 earnings after the

combined ratio worsened to 107.2%, from 102.9% a year ago. Excluding large fire claims and regulation-driven higher provisions, it would have been 102.3%. A higher combined ratio means lower underwriting profitability, while a ratio above 100% indicates an underwriting loss.

Notably, for FY26, ICICI Lombard's combined ratio was 103.4% versus the industry's 117.8%. ICICI's gross direct premium income grew 7.5% year-on-year to ₹8,318 crore in Q1. But dragged down by deeper underwriting losses, net profit fell 46% to ₹403 crore despite invest-

ment profits. RoE fell from 21% to 10%. While Irdai's tighter commission and expense-of-management norms proposed last month are expected to trigger a reset of the industry, ICICI Lombard's management expects large-scale multi-channel, multi-product insurers like itself to sustain on top.

The stock has remained largely flat over five years, and is trading at 23 times FY28 earnings based on consensus Bloomberg estimates. A rerating will hinge on whether the promised tech-led efficiencies can lead to underwriting profitability.

Consumption rises, investment recovery lags AI funds favour Taiwan, Korea over India

Niti Kiran & Abhinaba Saha
MUMBAI

The economy's two primary growth engines—consumption and investment—are moving at divergent speeds. While private consumption gained traction—rising 7.1% in the June quarter against 6.8% a year ago—investment has been uneven so far this fiscal year.

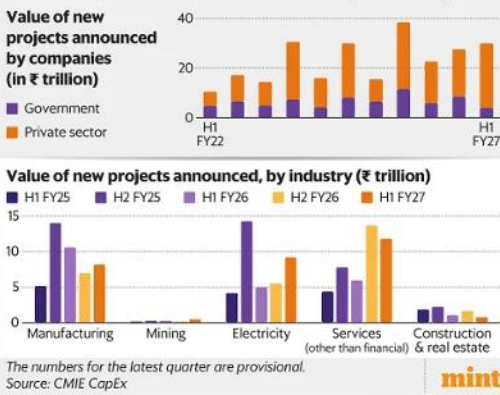
At first glance, new project announcements rose 33% year-on-year (y-o-y) during the April-September (H1) period of fiscal year 2027 (FY27) to ₹30 trillion, following a 46% surge in the corresponding period last fiscal year. New announcements rose 8.4% over H2FY26, according to Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data. However, a close look at the quarterly trend reveals the lopsided nature of these announcements. New project proposals in the September quarter contracted nearly 6% y-o-y, after a stellar 69% surge in the June quarter, and dropped almost 50% sequentially.

Moreover, India's entire private capex trajectory hinges on just two non-traditional sectors: data centres and nuclear power. They accounted for 25% of all capex proposals in September and almost 75% of all June-quarter announcements. Strip away the heavy concentration of these mega-investments, and the yearly decline in the September quarter deepens to 29%.

This reflects a broader "three-dimensional" concentration problem in India's private capex cycle, said Apoorva

Capex divergence

Private investment gains traction as consumption leads growth.



Javadekar, chief economist at Shriram Group. He said investments are driven by a handful of large companies, concentrated in a few states, including Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, and across a narrow set of sectors, notably power, data centres and semiconductors.

Key private mega-ventures announced during July-September included Adani Enterprises' Odisha Integrated Greenfield Aluminium Project worth ₹1.1 trillion, the Naraj Hyperscale AI Data Centre Hub Project worth ₹1.04 trillion and the Bhiv Bunder Nuclear Power Project (₹0.4 trillion), CMIE data showed.

Overall, projects worth ₹10.2 trillion were announced during this period, of which govern-

ment projects accounted for ₹1.3 trillion, while private-sector projects totalled ₹8.8 trillion. On a yearly basis, public projects were down nearly 27%, whereas private sector announcements fell roughly 2%. Beyond the two emerging segments of data centres and nuclear power that have led the recent shift, traditional sectors have shown a mixed investment trend. Manufacturing, once a major contributor to capex, saw a 23.2% decline in new investments in H1 FY27 compared with the same period last year.

Javadekar noted that micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), which are a key source of new manufacturing capacity, have come under pressure as higher debt servicing costs for supply chain and

working capital financing have coincided with shrinking profits in the post-Covid period. This has constrained their ability to fund large capex projects through bank financing.

Meanwhile, intentions in construction and real estate plummeted 31.5%. CMIE data showed. This left other conventional segments, like mining and electricity, to cushion the broader slowdown. New project announcements across both sectors nearly doubled in H1FY27 compared to H1FY26.

Looking ahead, Javadekar expects continued US tariff uncertainty to pose a significant risk to India Inc's export-linked capex decisions, potentially keeping new project announcements concentrated in data centres, power, and nuclear projects. Even after negotiations, India faces an 18% US tariff on exports, with the added risk of 100% tariffs on Russian oil purchases under the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026.

"Tariff uncertainty has not only affected capex plans within SEZs (special economic zones) but also stands to destabilize the FDI (Foreign Direct Investment) momentum for firms targeting India as an export hub," he said.

This is the final part of a five-part series evaluating the first half of fiscal year 2027. The first part examined the performance of domestic markets, the second looked at the best-performing asset classes, the third covered trends in private consumption, while the fourth assessed the primary markets.

niti.k@livemint.com

Dipti Sharma
dipti.sharma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Artificial intelligence (AI) markets are starting to see outflows. India isn't getting the money. Taiwan and South Korea, two of the biggest beneficiaries of the global AI investment boom, are showing early signs of cooling investor enthusiasm. But India, expected to benefit from any such rotation, is still seeing foreign money leave.

Since June, Taiwan- and South Korea-dedicated funds have attracted \$23.5 billion and \$28.4 billion, respectively, while India has seen outflows of \$4.5 billion, said Sunil Jain, vice president at Elara Capital.

Over the past six weeks, however, Taiwan has recorded outflows of \$796 million, South Korea \$3.17 billion and India \$1.48 billion. "So, it is only since the past six weeks, where we are seeing very early signs of redemptions from the two AI economies. India outflows also continue but the relative momentum is now turning better," he said.

The early outflows from Taiwan and South Korea may mark a pause in the AI trade, but there is little evidence yet of the money moving to India. Taiwan and Korea are closely linked markets, driven by the AI theme.

They are benefiting from a global AI capex boom that has created supply shortages, while the supply response is likely to take time, said Nitin Jain, chief executive, Kotak Asset Management Singapore.

Taking a turn for the better?

Past six weeks, South Korea and Taiwan have seen a flight of foreign capital but does India stand to regain?



Trade restrictions arising from US-China tensions have further constrained supply, boosting profitability in the near to medium term.

But concerns over US AI spending, cash flows and profitability have triggered bouts of volatility in the AI theme, leading to sharp swings across some segments, he said.

"The inflows in these markets reflected the optimism of investors in AI investments and the superiority and even exclusivity of some of the businesses in Taiwan/Korea to exploit the upsurge in the AI investments and the recent outflows reflect more the recent volatility in the theme and some profit booking rather than long term disbelief," Jain noted.

India, meanwhile, had been losing money as emerging-market investors reallocated towards the AI theme.

Tariffs and oil prices, along with the perceived negative

impact of AI on India, outweighed the positives from economic growth and earnings, Jain said.

Broader foreign investor inflows also remain tentative. After buying ₹23,331.85 crore in July and ₹22,846.78 crore in August, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) turned sellers again in September, offloading shares worth ₹43,001.52 crore, according to data from BSE and National Securities Depository Ltd.

The modest improvement reflects, to some extent, a growing confidence in corporate earnings and the resilience of the economy despite high oil prices and geopolitical risks, said market participants. But foreign inflows have yet to show a broad-based shift.

The rise in US 10-year Treasury yields could weigh on emerging-market sentiment. While large FCNR inflows will help mitigate risks for India, elevated energy prices and

yields could keep investors cautious despite resilient growth and strong corporate earnings.

Spot Brent crude oil prices have shot up nearly 66% in 2026, while the US 10-year Treasury yield has risen around 28%, according to Bloomberg data.

"Oil remains the principal risk, but if prices stay contained, strong growth, improving earnings and currency stability could help revive foreign investor interest," said Vinay Jaising, chief investment officer and head-equity, ASK Private Wealth.

India's relative position appears to be improving, although it is too early to call this a decisive shift, he said.

More importantly, Jaising believes confirmation would require sustained redemptions from the two AI-heavy markets alongside consistent inflows into India.

But the flows do not show that yet, said Lokesh Manik, senior analyst at Vallum Capital. Taiwan and Korea have swung from inflows to outflows, but India has not regained investor favour; the AI trade has simply paused.

For now, therefore, an artificial intelligence-trade pause is not the same as an India rotation.

Manik does not expect a return to broad-based rallies. With US 10-year yields at 5% and crude above \$100, returns are likely to come from a handful of micro themes with concentrated leadership, making this a stock-pickers' market.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Airtel Money eyes 5-year high UK IPO

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Mobile payments firm Airtel Money is looking to raise £529 million (\$700 million) for its shareholders in what could be London's biggest initial public offering in five years.

Existing investors including the Qatar Investment Authority and Mastercard Inc. are selling shares at a fixed price of £1.96, which would give Airtel Money, officially Airtel Mobile Commerce NV, a market value of £5.3 billion, according to terms of the deal seen by Bloomberg.

The valuation is lower than the \$8 billion to \$9 billion range reported previously, implying a discount to boost demand.

Airtel Money's offering may be the largest for London's stock market since IPO volumes plummeted after a pandemic-era boom. A successful debut would bring new impetus to the city's efforts to attract international listings.

The selling investors are offering 270 million existing shares in the deal, while Bharti Airtel International may sell an additional 27 million shares through an overallotment option after the stock starts trading on the London Stock Exchange on 9 October. Airtel Money is expected to be eligible for inclusion in FTSE UK indexes.

Airtel Money is pushing ahead with the IPO, even as other firms delay their IPOs, both in Europe and the US. Fixing the price range enables Airtel Money to simplify the offering structure, which could help get the deal completed even if markets turn volatile.

Accenture predicts higher AI spending as token costs fall

Company's shares soar after upbeat management commentary; Infosys, Wipro rise on NYSE

Jas Bardia
jas.bardia@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Accenture Plc. expects companies to spend more on automation tools as the costs of deploying them reduce, even as it passes more productivity benefits to clients.

While overall tech budgets have remained largely unchanged from last year, newer and cheaper AI models offer clients an incentive to spend more on AI, Julie Sweet, chief executive of the world's largest IT services company said.

"So, the way we think about the dynamic is, the more that token costs go down over the next couple of years, the more it's going to enable companies to use AI in more places and at scale. And to use AI, they need to change their processes, reinvent their work, build out that AI stack in order to really do it. And all of that is what clients are turning to us," Sweet said at a post-earnings conference call.

A token is the fundamental unit of data processed by large language models (LLMs) such as OpenAI's ChatGPT or Anthropic's Claude. They are essentially AI's building blocks used to analyze and generate text, images and software codes.

Accenture's commentary comes on the back of AI advancements that have threatened to erode the revenue of tech services firms, as much of the work they handle can be automated by automation tools.

The management also added that AI-led revenue deflation, even though persistent, is now predictable.

"We are definitely giving more productivity due to AI, and overall, though, the impact has been steady. So, we're offsetting (revenue deflation) as we have in the past with new kinds of work,



Accenture's earnings cheered investors, with the company's shares rising 22% on the New York Stock Exchange.

more scope," she said.

The management's upbeat commentary was reflected in its report card. Accenture closed the fiscal year ended August with \$74.2 billion revenue, up 6% from the previous year. A little more than a fourth of its revenue growth

Shares of Infosys and Wipro followed as well, gaining 9% and 8%, respectively.

Earnings were in line with its own estimates -- the company ended with a 5% growth in local currency, in line with its June estimates. The company bounced back from a period of low new

in revenue.

The company reported a net profit of \$8.5 billion, up 8.8% from the preceding year. Profitability jumped as well, with the company reporting 15.4% in operating margins, up 70 basis points from a year earlier. One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point. The management attributed this to better deal pricing and delivery efficiencies.

The company expects revenue growth between 3-6% in local currency this year, of which 2-2.5% is expected to come from acquisitions.

"They have beaten expectations. Uptick in small deals which are discretionary in nature, quick mobilization of contracts which implies faster deal conversions to revenue, and better performance of recent acquisitions and Accenture Federal business have contributed to these numbers, which were better-than-expected," said Karan Uppal, lead IT analyst at Phillip Capital.

Accenture's earnings and commentary are seen as a bellwether for India's IT services sector, with some of the country's largest tech services firms including Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Infosys Ltd, HCL Technologies Ltd and Wipro Ltd, announcing their second quarter results beginning next week. To be sure, Accenture follows a September-August fiscal calendar, compared to Indian IT's April-March.

"Overall positive readthroughs for Indian IT companies -- There is no further pressure on pricing and client spending is intact for digital core, data foundation and enterprise AI," Uppal of Phillips Capital said.

The company expects about \$8 billion in acquisitions this year, even as \$3 billion is expected from cybersecurity deals that were deferred to last month.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

HC nixes Vedanta plea on bauxite pact

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliwala

MUMBAI

In a setback to Vedanta Ltd, the Orissa High Court on Thursday dismissed the conglomerate's plea seeking enforcement of a 2004 agreement with the Odisha Mining Corp (OMC) for supply of 150 million tonnes of bauxite at prices linked to production costs and royalty.

The ruling could sharply raise the cost of bauxite for its aluminium business, putting pressure on a key cost advantage for one of India's largest producers of the metal.

The division bench of the court held that Vedanta could not rely on agreements that had been terminated and had become unworkable following changes in mining law. The petition was filed by uninvolved Vedanta Ltd in 2023.

The ruling is significant as bauxite is the key raw material for Vedanta's Lanjigarh refinery, which supplies alumina to its aluminium smelters.



The ruling could sharply raise the cost of bauxite for Vedanta's aluminium business.

Vedanta had argued that it had made large investments in Odisha based on an assurance from the state that it would receive long-term bauxite supplies at a stable price.

Vedanta said it had invested more than ₹6,000 crore in setting up its Lanjigarh alumina refinery and had to initially source bauxite from outside because supplies from the proposed mines did not begin. This led to losses of more than ₹3,000 crore, it told the court.

Under the 2004 agreement, OMC had agreed to supply 150

million tonnes of bauxite to Vedanta with pricing linked to the cost of production and a royalty component.

Vedanta later sought to retain this pricing framework under the state's 2018 Long Term Linkage (LTL) policy, under which the floor price for auctions was linked to cost of production plus a 50% margin.

The dispute arose after Odisha changed the pricing mechanism following a 2019 amendment to Rule 45 of the Minerals (Other than Atomic and Hydro Carbons Energy Minerals) Concession Rules. The state directed OMC to use the average sale price method to fix the floor price for bauxite sold through national e-auctions.

Vedanta challenged the move, arguing the rule was meant for mine auctions and not for commercial sale of mined bauxite. It said the change had substantially increased its input costs.

The court rejected the argument, noting OMC had terminated the earlier JV pacts in September 2015 after changes to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act. Vedanta did not challenge the termination at the time, and it had therefore attained finality, it said.

"The company is evaluating the order and the legal recourse available to it. The order does not impact the supply of bauxite to Vedanta Aluminium," a company spokesperson said in an email response. OMC did not respond.

The court has allowed OMC to take further action in accordance with law, including raising demands based on the average sale price methodology. It also vacated interim orders that had protected Vedanta over the proceedings.

dipali.banka@live-mint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

PepsiCo, Monster challenge label ban

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

PepsiCo and Monster Beverage have sued India's food regulator for banning their use of the "energy drink" label, non-public court filings show, escalating a regulatory fight that has jolted a sector expected to be worth \$1.6 billion by 2028.

The food safety regulator ordered makers of high-caffeine beverages sold as "energy drinks" to stop using the description on 30 June amid growing concerns about the health risk of such products - part of an unprecedented food safety crackdown.

In a court filing in New Delhi, PepsiCo India said the prohibition will have "grave commercial consequences" and hurt "substantial investments," given that it had 492 million bottles and 26 million cans with those labels in circulation on 31 July.



The use of the 'energy drink' label has been banned.

PepsiCo was not given an opportunity to explain its position before the directive, and so the decision should be set aside, said the 358-page 29 September filing, which is not public and has not appeared in media but was seen by Reuters.

The regulator privately gave the companies 90 days to drop "energy drink", or any similar description, from high-caffeine beverages, saying that using that term breached regulations, Reuters has reported.

Healthy realty projects may escape pain from developer's bankruptcy

FROM PAGE 1

Raheja Developers, Super-tech, Today Homes and Ajnara--their arms are facing bankruptcy proceedings. However, it is not clear yet if the new regulations would apply to these ongoing cases as well or only to fresh ones. A decision on the issue will soon be taken and notified, the people said.

The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, as amended in April, also backs project-wise insolvency.

The IBBI has not estimated the number of projects and homebuyers likely to benefit from the regulation tweak, said the people cited above. The number of dwelling units in India's stalled real estate projects was pegged at 4,12,000 with a total value of ₹4.08 trillion, as per an Indian

Banks' Association estimate, cited in a July 2023 report of an expert panel led by former G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant.

Of these, more than half were in the National Capital Region alone. These included assets of realtors facing insolvency resolution. As per the new framework, once the CoC is formed after the bankruptcy application against a real estate developer is admitted, it will be able to conduct a project-wise analysis and suggest exclusion of projects that don't require insolvency intervention.

Queries emailed to the insolvency regulator and to the corporate affairs ministry on Wednesday remained unanswered until press time.

Project-wise insolvency in real estate has been debated at length in recent years, and the current proposal draws from a discussion paper that the IBBI

had floated in late June.

"It will be a project-wise treatment after insolvency admission of the developer and formation of the CoC, so that the CoC can take an accurate and well-informed decision," said one of the people cited above, requesting anonymity.

A second person in the know concurred. "Project exclusion is being left to the CoC's wisdom, but ultimately, it has to be approved by the NCLT," this person said.

Anoop Rawat, partner and national practice head (Insolvency & Restructuring) at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co, said: "This provision is necessary because it shifts the resolution approach from corporate debtor rescue to project rescue and homebuyer rescue, which is what the Supreme Court, in the Mansi



Project-wise insolvency in real estate has been debated at length in recent years.

Brar case, said was needed." In the Mansi Brar case last year, the apex court observed that real estate insolvency should, as a rule, proceed on a project-specific basis rather than against the entire corporate debtor, barring exceptional circumstances. It also

directed the IBBI to frame guidelines for realty insolvency, in consultation with the Real Estate Regulatory Authority (Rera).

The implementation of this plan is, however, going to be watched closely. "A developer-debtor is a sin-

gle corporate entity and any credit facility provided to the developer does not get converted into a 'project finance', whereas a project-specific insolvency can operate in isolation by excluding the viable projects," said Yogendra Aldak, executive partner at Lakshmikumaran and Sridharan Attorneys.

To implement the proposal effectively, the regulator, in its June discussion paper, suggested mechanisms, such as enhanced project-wise disclosures, ring-fencing of funds, project-specific books, measures to account for homebuyer preferences, coordination between the resolu-

tion professional and the Rera, Aldak said. "The latest IBBI proposal addresses a genuine structural problem in real estate insolvency," said Vishal Gehrana, partner-designate at legal services firm Karanjawala & Co.

At the same time, safeguards need to be carefully worked out for its effective implementation, he said. "The regulation should clearly address who manages an excluded project, how existing creditor and home-

buyer interests are protected, what happens to the moratorium in relation to an excluded project, and how project assets, liabilities and funds are dealt with after exclusion,"

Gehrana said.

For context, when a developer goes into the CIRP, it triggers moratorium under Section 14 of the insolvency law without exceptions. This freezes prior payments for healthy, near-complete projects where there is no default, stopping construction, causing labour and contractor exit, blocking home loan disbursements and delaying home registrations, said Rawat.

This traps innocent homebuyers for years without possession or refund, while the cost of project completion escalates. Project-wise insolvency will help by ring-fencing the Section 14 moratorium and CIRP to only the defaulting projects, allowing construction, funding, possession and registration to continue unimpeded in all healthy projects, Rawat said.

MOVES

A weekly list of C-Suiters who have moved up the corporate ladder either within or outside their companies.

Anup Deshmukh	Appointed as India managing director at Danfoss Power Solutions
Bhavna Kumar	Appointed as managing director--human resources at BNP Paribas India
Bhavna Singh	Appointed as head--corporate communications at EssilorLuxottica India
Bijon Pani	Appointed as chief investment officer--alternatives at Godrej Asset Management
Deepak Somasundaram	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Chettinad Group
Dheeraj Kumar Rai	Appointed as director--manufacturing at Carraro India
Dr. Rajan Pental	Appointed as financial services sector leader at PwC India
Gaurav Hazrati	Appointed as business head--loyalty, marketplaces & financial services at IndiGo
Gautam Mehra	Appointed as chief human resources officer at IFP Petro
Geetika Mishra	Appointed as chief procurement officer at Spark Minda
Karthik Krishnamurthy	Appointed as global chief executive officer at Wipro Aerospace
Kunal Jha	Appointed as chief financial officer at Webasto
Laxminarayan Toshniwal	Appointed as CFO at Voith India Region, & CFO at Voith Hydro
Manish Bhardwaj	Appointed as senior vice-president & chief human resources officer at Emami Agrotech
Nupur Shrivastava	Appointed as chief human resources officer at MiPhi Semiconductors
Partha Ghosh	Appointed as executive vice-president & group head--communications at JSW Group
Pooja Venkatram	Appointed as director & head--human resources at BASF India
Priyaranjan Jha	Appointed as global head--GCCs & country president, India at Sandoz India
Radhika Arora	Appointed as chief human resources officer at DCM Shriram Chemicals
Samir Dewan	Appointed as group chief executive officer at BajajCapital
Shweta Govil Singh	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Shriram Farm Solutions
Sudarshan Patodia	Appointed as chief financial officer at Rainbow Children's Medicare
Sudhanshu Tripathi	Appointed as chief marketing officer at Nucleus Software
Sudip Nag	Appointed as managing director at Jindal Power Ltd
Suman Yadav	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Wakefit Innovations
Suresh Venkatesan	Appointed as whole-time director & CEO at CRIF Credit Information Services
Umang Papneja	Appointed as executive vice-chairman & chief executive officer at Avendus Wealth Management
Upendra Chaturvedi	Appointed as chief technology officer at Bandhan Bank
Vaibhav Verma	Appointed as chief supply chain officer at Crystal Crop Protection

Source: Accord India, executive search worldwide

Tech CEOs privately questioned Amodeli for sounding AI alarm bells

Amrith Ramkumar & Josh Dawsey

WASHINGTON

After agreeing to sign a statement of principles to keep artificial-intelligence models safe Tuesday, AI chief executives surrounded President Trump outside the White House to present the image of a unified industry addressing the public's fears.

Behind the scenes, industry leaders including Jensen Huang of Nvidia had just questioned Anthropic's Dario Amodei about his warnings about the dangers of AI, people familiar with the matter said.

The executives asked Amodei why he was being so extreme in public about the capabilities of AI models and risks they posed following a lunch in the East Room with about two dozen CEOs. Amodei told the other executives that it is important to be honest with the public about model capabilities and not play down risks, some of the people said.

Their conversation occurred with a smaller group of executives and White House aides and advisers who were hashing out the principles in the Roosevelt Room, some of the people said.

Trump and House Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.) got the top AI companies to agree to the principles at the lunch, but the questioning of Amodei is the latest indication of tensions under the surface between Anthropic and the rest of the industry that could hinder the sector's plan for "self regulation" using model evaluations and internal controls.

Amodei has previously criticized the White House and competitors for playing down safety concerns and warned about AI models carrying out cyberattacks and extreme job losses driven by the technology, making him a target for criticism by many in Washington and Silicon Valley.

Jay Clayton, director of national intelligence, said in a statement that the meeting was "one of the most, if not the most, constructive and collegial industry meetings I have ever seen."

"The focal point was, 'What is best for the American people and globe?' and that focal point drove agreement," said the candidate to be Trump's next AI "czar" coordinating policy across the administration.

On Tuesday, Amodei told reporters "we can win safely" if the industry and administration work together, and Trump praised him for being "great." The duo dined together at the White House Sunday for their first face-to-face meeting.

Anthropic has sought to mend fences with the admin-



Nvidia's CEO was among the execs at White House event who called out Amodei for warning about AI's capabilities.

istration recently and is gearing up for an initial public offering it hopes will value the company at some \$2 trillion. The company is still reeling from a pair of bruising battles with the administration earlier this year that included a 2-week shutdown of two of its models due to security concerns and being blacklisted by the Pentagon over a dispute regarding how AI is used in the military.

Tuesday's principles were the result of months of discussions over how to prevent AI cyberattacks following the release of Anthropic's Mythos and similar models earlier this year. The administration is testing powerful models before they are released publicly, but recent hacks by AI models have demonstrated the need for stronger reviews when models are being trained and developed, industry executives say.

This summer, Anthropic, OpenAI and Google had coalesced around an approach being considered by the administration for a self-regulatory organization similar to the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority, which oversees brokerage firms.

Huang, Meta Platforms CEO Mark Zuckerberg and SpaceX's Elon Musk told Trump they worried the idea would concentrate too much power in the leading AI companies, so the idea was scrapped. *The Wall Street Journal* previously reported.

That structure also would have involved many of the ideas included in Tuesday's principles such as stronger internal reviews of models during development and external testing.

That highlighted the pressure facing the White House and industry due to public concerns about AI and the data centers powering it.

Zuckerberg in particular played a key role in finaliz-

ing Tuesday's principles, frequently talking to Trump and others in the administration including Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick, who oversees a key government AI testing unit, some of the people said. He has emerged alongside Huang to champion the White House's light-touch approach and push back against calls from researchers at Anthropic and OpenAI to start slowing down model development if needed in coordination with the government.

The push for the dinner began when he and Johnson sat next to each other at the State Dinner with China's Xi Jinping last week and talked about AI policy, some of the people said. Zuckerberg and Huang then tried to coordinate top CEOs while Trump and Johnson organized the lunch to build consensus, these people said. Semafor previously reported on the conversations.

When Amodei brought up his safety concerns during the lunch, Zuckerberg responded that the best way to address them was by following through on the principles as an industry, some of the people said.

Meta has aligned itself with the White House after previously facing criticism from Trump for suspending his social-media accounts following the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol.

In Trump's second term, the company settled a lawsuit over the move, rolled back fact-checking protocols, hired Trump-friendly executives and donated to the president's pet causes.

Zuckerberg was smiling and laughing with the president Tuesday while taking questions from the press. "We want to give the American people and our customers confidence that the technology works in the way that we intend," he said.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.
feedback@livemint.com

The questioning of Amodei is the latest indication of simmering tensions between Anthropic, rest of the industry

company settled a lawsuit over the move, rolled back fact-checking protocols, hired Trump-friendly executives and donated to the president's pet causes.

Zuckerberg was smiling and laughing with the president Tuesday while taking questions from the press. "We want to give the American people and our customers confidence that the technology works in the way that we intend," he said.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.
feedback@livemint.com

U.S. pressure campaign leaves Iranian tankers stranded in Asian waters

Dozens of vessels are adrift as the U.S. threatens sanctions on countries coming to their aid

Jon Emont
feedback@livemint.com
COLOMBO, SRI LANKA

Some 15 miles off the southwest coast of Sri Lanka, around 20 empty Iranian oil tankers are stranded, drifting with their engines idled as food, fuel and fresh water run short.

They are the most visible consequence of the new pressure campaign by the U.S. to bring Iran to heel. Dozens of Iranian or Iranian-linked tankers that had participated in the shadowy trade of getting sanctioned oil to China have been stuck in the waters near Asian countries like Sri Lanka and Malaysia since July, when the U.S. reimposed its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Then, in recent weeks, U.S. officials have pressured Sri Lanka into blocking local ships from provisioning the tankers and their crews, according to Sri Lankan government documents and companies that provide provisions to those ships.

The Trump administration is pursuing a hardball strategy aimed at forcing Iran into making concessions in the monthslong conflict. In recent days, the U.S.—which slapped Iran with many new sanctions this summer—has warned Iran's trading partners to ditch the country.

Before the war, ships carrying Iranian oil would ferry the crude to international waters off Malaysia, where they transferred it to other tankers that would then transport it to Chinese refineries, an elaborate operation designed to evade U.S. sanctions on Iranian oil.

The tankers would then sail back to Iran, pick up more oil, and do it all again. Some tankers are Iranian. Others sail under other flags but have been sanctioned by the U.S. because of their involvement in such subterfuge.

Now, the blockade has dealt this trade a blow. Iranian ships can't return home. The recent U.S. sanctions blitz means that some Asian ports that once serviced them now refuse them out of fear of U.S. sanctions, leaving the tankers adrift at sea.

The squeeze has also affected containerships bringing goods such as corn and industrial materials to Iran.

On a recent journey to international waters off the coast of Malaysia chartered by the U.S. advocacy group United Against Nuclear Iran, empty, rusted Iranian-linked ships floated high in the water. Many have been anchored there since July.

"When they finish their jobs they park here," said Charlie Brown, a researcher with UANI. "They don't want to go back because of the blockade."

One was the *Elva*, a sanctioned tanker that had loaded up with oil on Iran's Kharg Island and crossed the Strait of Hormuz in June, according to financial data provider LSEG. It has been lingering off Malaysia since discharging the crude to another vessel in a ship-to-ship transfer in August. Sailors on the *Elva* appeared bored. One



Dozens of Iranian or Iranian-linked tankers have been stuck in the waters near Asian countries since July.

started dancing when he saw a passing boat, waving and shaking his hips.

Oil analysts expect that the last of the Iranian oil still waiting to be transferred to buyers will run out in the coming weeks, with payments to Iran to conclude by year's end. "All revenues drop to zero for Iran by December," said Homayoun Falakshahi, head of Crude Oil Analysis at Kpler.

Over the last two months, many of the tankers have left the area off Malaysia for the Indian Ocean and the coast of Sri Lanka, which is closer to Iran and has a history of providing fuel, fresh provisions and repair crews to Iranian ships.

But in August, the U.S. Embassy in the Sri Lankan capital of Colombo informed the government that it was tracking 19 Iranian tankers off the country's western coast and urged officials to tell local port service providers to deny them support or risk U.S. secondary sanctions, according to Sri Lankan government documents

seen by *The Wall Street Journal*.

Around this time, many of the Iranian vessels pulled away from Sri Lanka's territorial waters, with many drifting deeper into the Indian Ocean, their engines idled to conserve fuel, according to ship-tracking data and Sri Lankan maritime businesses.

When, in early September, two Iranian-flagged container vessels anchored in the port limits of Colombo, Sri Lanka's port authority stated in a letter seen by the *Journal* that it wasn't "prudent to provide services to Iranian-flagged" vessels because of the risk of U.S. sanctions.

In mid-September, the U.S. Embassy in Colombo conducted a three-day training session with more than 40 Sri Lankan officials, laying out the risk of U.S. penalties if shipping agents, fuel providers and other service companies "knowingly or unknowingly" support sanctioned vessels.

"Sri Lanka sits at a strategic crossroads for global commerce, bringing both tremendous opportunity and the need for vigilance," U.S. Ambassador to Sri Lanka Eric Meyer said in a September statement. The U.S. was taking decisive action to stamp out sanctions evasion by "sharing U.S. expertise with our Sri Lankan partners."

The State Department said that the U.S. will "continue to disrupt, expose, and dismantle" Iran's illicit oil trade, and called on the international community to hold Iran accountable. The State Department didn't reply to a separate request for comment on the conditions facing the crews of the Iranian-linked vessels.

Dubai-based shipping agents for the tankers have pleaded with businesses in Sri Lanka to send out fresh food and fuel. But representatives of Sri Lankan shipping companies say it has become difficult to secure approval from port authorities to provide any services for Iranian vessels.

The owner of a Sri Lankan shipping repair company that dispatched a team to an Iranian ship just before the onset of the

new restrictions found that provisions on the tanker were dwindling. While repair crews are normally fed on board and can wash there, the tanker's crew told them to bring their own food and warned them that they couldn't wash because the vessel needed to conserve fresh water, according to the company official.

Another Sri Lankan shipper said he has received desperate calls for food and provisions from agents of the tankers, but Sri Lankan authorities weren't approving supply visits to Iranian ships.

Thushara Rodrigo, a spokesman for Sri Lanka's foreign ministry, acknowledged the risk that sanctioned ships might run out of food, fuel and water. He said that if ships require emergency

provisions, private companies could be reluctant to supply the tankers and risk sanctions.

Other Iran-linked vessels have ventured to waters near India and China. Some of those that have remained in the familiar waters near Malaysia have moved north from an area known as the Eastern Outer Port Limits, where ship-to-ship transfers of Iranian oil have normally taken place. UANI analysts say this could be the result of stepped-up Malaysian enforcement activity. A Malaysian coast-guard official didn't respond to a request for comment.

On a recent trip, a pair of small local sampan vessels pulled up to the *Parnia*, an Iranian cargo ship idling off the coast of southeastern Malaysia. *The Parnia* had been stranded there since July when it returned from China

stacked with containers, according to ship-tracking data. The sailors onboard the sampans are known to go from ship to ship, selling basic supplies like cigarettes and beer.

Iranian ships were guarded when they were contacted by radio. In response to an inquiry

about whether there was enough food onboard, one ship responded in terse Farsi: "Do not worry about our food."

Advocates of a tougher policy against Iran say that targeting those that provision the ships could raise the cost—and risk—of owning and servicing vessels that carry Iranian oil and other goods, making it difficult to carry out Iran's shadow oil trade. In August, the U.S. sanctioned a network of companies that provided fuel to Iranian ships.

"A vessel that is sitting and not carrying oil is just a hole in the budget," said Mark Wallace, UANI's CEO, who has called for tougher U.S. sanctions against Malaysian groups that supply the ships.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.

Oil analysts expect the last of the Iranian oil still waiting to be transferred to buyers to run out in coming weeks

Apple's biggest battleground for foldable phones is China

Hannah Miao
feedback@livemint.com
BEIJING

Demand for some foldable phones in China is surging, even before Apple's new foldable iPhone Duo arrives.

That suggests an opportunity for Apple to expand what has been a niche category—if it can overcome competition from Chinese brands.

Winning over China is key to Apple's fortunes. The country makes up more than a third of global folding smartphone sales and is the largest single market for foldables, according to research firm Counterpoint Research.

Chinese company Huawei is currently the market leader in

China, both for foldables and smartphones generally. Huawei released its first folding smartphone in 2019. Other Chinese brands, including Xiaomi, Vivo, Oppo and Honor, have been selling foldables for years.

After Apple announced its first foldable iPhone in early September, sales during the following four days of Huawei's Pura X Max—which has similar dimensions to the Duo—grew about 77% from the same period a week earlier, according to Huawei. More than 1.4 million units of the Pura X Max have been sold since its release in April, according to Huawei.

Xiaomi's 18 Fold, another passport-size folding phone, notched record first-week

sales for the company's foldables after its release in early September, a representative said.

Richard Yu, chairman of Huawei's consumer business, said the company has invested heavily to make breakthroughs in screen reliability and camera quality for its foldables.

"I know how hard-earned these achievements were, which is why we are a leader in this business," said Yu.

Apple didn't respond to a request for comment.

Foldables are still a relatively niche product, making up roughly 4% of smartphone sales in China and about 2% globally, according to Counterpoint. They can be fragile, and it is harder to put a good camera on a folding smartphone.

Still, brands hope foldables



Huawei and other Chinese competitors reported higher demand for foldables after announcement of iPhone Duo.

can attract higher-end customers. Huawei's Pura X Max starts at the equivalent of more than \$1,600. It also has been selling trifolding smartphones that unfurl twice, like a pamphlet. Huawei's second-generation trifold, called the Mate

XT2, released in early September, starts at nearly \$3,000.

The iPhone Duo starts at \$1,999 in the U.S. and 15,999 yuan in China, equivalent to nearly \$2,400. Apple has said consumers in the U.S., China and many other countries will

be able to preorder the iPhone Duo on Oct. 16, and it will be available a week later.

Fans of foldables often use the devices to work on the go. The larger screens help with multitasking and reviewing documents.

Wang Rui, an 18-year-old college student in Beijing, said he was considering buying the Mate XT2 and went to Huawei's flagship store in Beijing to check it out. He also visited Apple's store across the street in hopes of testing the Duo, but it wasn't on display yet. He said he has previously used foldable phones made by Oppo and Vivo.

"Like cutting-edge technology," said Wang, pulling up

stock-market data on the Mate XT2's 10.2-inch screen. "As of now, Apple hasn't reached this level yet."

Despite Apple's late entry into the market, Counterpoint projects the company will sell up to six million foldable

iPhones this year and take a quarter of the global foldables market. The firm predicts Apple will beat out Huawei's 22% global market share.

Foldable pioneer Samsung, which has only a small presence in China, is expected to maintain its lead with a 38% global share in foldables, according to Counterpoint.

Huawei is effectively barred from selling its products in the U.S. It has been blacklisted by

the U.S. government since 2019 and is effectively blocked from using American technology.

The company has gotten around these U.S. barriers by developing its own chips and operating systems. Its latest lineup of smartphones, the Mate 90 Series, released Thursday, uses technology to layer circuits within a single chip, aiming to boost computing power despite lacking access to cutting-edge machinery.

The global shortage of memory chips has pushed up smartphone prices. Sun Lei, a 50-year-old Huawei customer, said he was interested in buying the Mate XT2 trifold phone: "The only thing holding me back right now is money."

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.



NEWS
NUMBERS

2.2%

THE GROWTH rate of the US economy in April-June, driven by consumer spending and business investment, but decelerating from a 2.5% pace in the first quarter.

₹0.115

THE PER-MESSAGE fee Meta is charging Indian businesses for WhatsApp service messages, once their monthly free quota of 1,000 messages is exhausted.

\$2.89 tn

THE ESTIMATED total cost of US wars in Iraq and Syria by 2050, including future veteran care, per Brown University, as the US completes its withdrawal from Iraq.

29,582

THE NUMBER of units sold in the 205-340cc motorcycle segment in August, marking a 72.03% year-on-year growth, led by the TVS Ronin 225.

74%

THE PERCENTAGE of India's high-net-worth entrepreneurs intending to relocate overseas or obtain another residency, according to an HSBC report.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Rural distress dents tractor sales in Sep

India's weakest monsoon in over a decade dented rural spending in September and weighed on tractor sales, data showed on Thursday, while urban demand supported sales of passenger vehicles.

The June-September monsoon was 12.6% below normal this year, fuelling concerns over crop yields, rural demand and food inflation in Asia's No.3 economy.

Mahindra & Mahindra, India's largest tractor maker, reported a 21% drop in tractor sales during the month, while smaller rival Escorts Kubota posted a 16.7% decline.

"Lower farm incomes and, as a result, rising rural indebtedness hurt purchasing power and demand for consumer goods and services, while supply shortages can push up food prices and stoke inflationary pressures," said Rohit Azad, an economics professor at Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru University.

REUTERS



Tewolde Gebremariam is the second foreign CEO and MD to head the loss-making airline.

Gebremariam takes charge at Air India

Tewolde Gebremariam formally assumed charge as chief executive officer (CEO) and managing director (MD) of Air India on Thursday.

Gebremariam, whose appointment was announced on 5 August, received security clearance this week.

An Ethiopian, Gebremariam is taking over at a time when the airline is working on its ambitious expansion plans amid multiple external headwinds. He is the second foreign CEO and MD to head loss-making Air India.

During a town hall with the staff on Monday, Gebremariam said cost discipline must become part of Air India's culture and identified sustainable profitability, safety and operational reliability as key priorities for the airline. He also plans to introduce programmes that reward employees for ideas that deliver measurable cost savings and improve operational efficiency.

PTI

ATF, commercial LPG prices raised

Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by a steep ₹16 per litre to ₹137 from Thursday, while the price of commercial LPG was increased by ₹62.50 per 19-kg cylinder in step with firming international benchmarks, according to state-owned oil companies.

The revision comes after ATF prices were raised by ₹6.28 per litre in September, following a ₹5 per litre increase in August. ATF accounts for up to 40% of operating costs for airlines.

Commercial LPG prices were raised by ₹9.50 per 19-kg cylinder in September, following two consecutive monthly reductions of ₹192 in August and ₹183.50 in July. The cuts came after commercial LPG prices had surged to a record high in June amid disruptions to global energy supplies and elevated international prices.

The latest changes are based on movements in international benchmark prices and the rupee-dollar exchange rate.

PTI

Adani Green BESS capacity at 6.6 GWh

Adani Green Energy Ltd has expanded its operational battery energy storage system (BESS) capacity to 6.63 GWh, which can store enough clean energy to power around two million homes a day. With this, the company has achieved almost 70% of its target for fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

The 6.63 GWh BESS supports peak electricity demand of cities like Nagpur, Patna or Visakhapatnam for several hours. The company now accounts for more than 50% of India's operational BESS capacity of about 12.6 GWh, Adani Green said in a statement on Thursday.

The firm said it has achieved the 6.63 GWh milestone within 14 months of commencing on-site BESS construction at Khavda, and is on track to add over 10 GWh of BESS capacity in FY27. As of June, Adani Green had 3.55 GWh of operational BESS capacity. The company is targeting 50 GWh of storage capacity over the next five years.

PTI

Mayank Khanduja joins Bessemer Venture Partners

Bessemer Venture Partners has appointed Mayank Khanduja as partner in its India practice. He will focus on early-stage investments, partnering with founders from their first institutional round onwards.

Khanduja's previous stints include Elevation Capital and McKinsey, and he brings 15 years of venture investing experience, across consumer tech, gaming, healthcare, artificial intelligence (AI) and deeptech. He has backed companies including ShareChat, NoBroker, PlaySimple Games, Jeh Aerospace, MOC Cancer Care, Loop Health, Atlys, Seekho, General Autonomy and PierSight.

Bessemer has been active in India for the two decades. It recently announced the raise of \$5.75 billion of capital globally to back founders from seed through growth in the AI era.

PRIYAMVADAC

NSE gets Sebi nod to launch corporate bond index futures

The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) on Thursday said it received a no-objection certificate from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to introduce futures contracts on a corporate bond index.

The proposed product will give market participants an exchange-traded instrument to manage corporate bond market risk and help develop India's corporate bond derivatives ecosystem, NSE said in a statement.

Corporate bond index futures are expected to offer an additional avenue for risk management, portfolio hedging and price discovery, while supporting market-making by enabling participants to manage risks arising from their corporate bond portfolios.

The launch of the product, however, is subject to requisite approval from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the NSE statement noted.

REUTERS

NoBroker targets 1st profit with AI aid

Startup NoBroker is using artificial intelligence (AI) to cut tasks previously handled by people, putting the Indian real estate company closer to profitability.

The online platform, which offers rentals, property sales and services like home loans, movers, and interior designing, has harnessed AI for tasks such as sales and customer service, co-founder and chief technology officer Akhil Gupta said. It now envisages profit in about 10 months—its first since its founding more than a decade ago—paving the way for a stock market debut, he said. "We avoided hiring hundreds of personnel," Gupta said in an interview. "The impact on our cost structure is massive."

NoBroker has deployed 65 distinct AI agents across its divisions to take care of user queries, qualify leads, reactivate customers and schedule interactions, Gupta said. About 30% of its call volume is now handled without human intervention.

BLOOMBERG

Govt to intervene as private refiners cap diesel sales

No oil marketing company is permitted to restrict sales, says petroleum secretary

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Centre will raise the issue of recent diesel sales restrictions with private refiners and ask them to roll back the move, said Neeraj Mittal, secretary, Union ministry of petroleum and natural gas. Addressing reporters on Thursday, Mittal said no oil marketing company (OMC) is permitted to restrict fuel sales.

Private operators Jio-bp and Nayara Energy have both capped diesel sales. *Mint* first reported that Jio-bp reinstated a limit of 50 litres per transaction. *Bloomberg* recently reported that Nayara has similarly capped diesel sales at 70-200 litres per transaction.

Responding to a question on the restrictions, the secretary said: "Nobody is allowed to put a cap on sales. So, if they are putting a cap on sale, we will take it up. We will tell them that it is not acceptable, it is not done. In the past also, letters have been issued. So, the same thing applies even today."

Union petroleum and natural gas minister Hardeep Singh Puri said the government is "always in touch with" private fuel retailers.

Reliance Industries Ltd-backed Jio-bp, which accounts for a fifth of India's roughly 10,000 private fuel retail pumps, had previously restricted diesel sales and imposed a diesel procurement quota for its pumps in April. India has a total of around 100,000 fuel pumps. Rosneft-backed Nayara Energy has more than 7,000 petrol



REUTERS

pumps in the country.

"Nayara Energy continues to maintain fuel supply across its nationwide dealer retail network and ensure seamless access to fuel for its customers. We remain committed to serving the Indian market and meeting the demand for fuel across the length and breadth of the country," Nayara Energy said in response to an email query from *Mint*. Queries emailed to Jio-bp on Thursday evening remained unanswered at presstime.

Jio-bp and Nayara Energy are key exporters of petroleum products. A recent report by Finnish think tank Centre for Research on Energy and the Clean Air said Russia imported a record 172,000 tonnes of petroleum products in August, with most of the supplies coming from India. It noted that supplies from Nayara's Vadinar refinery comprised about 70% of Russia's imports.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

UPI volumes, value fall in Sep after MDR announced

FROM PAGE 1

Reeju Datta, co-founder of payments gateway Cashfree Payments, said UPI use is typically higher in the first half as people get salaries and pay bills and installments. While September saw a sharper fall in the second half than in earlier months, the average daily transaction volume for the month was the highest ever at 802 million, with an average daily value of ₹97,013 crore.

Between January and August 2026, the daily transaction count in the second half was 3-5% lower than in the first, said Datta. The decline was 6% in September. The decline in daily value of UPI payments in the second half, by comparison, was in 10-19% range during January-August; in September, it was 17%.

Some industry experts describe the development as a knee-jerk reaction, given that MDR will take effect only from 15 October. "We are seeing more conversations around the cost of higher-value UPI transactions, particularly from merchants with tighter margins," said Kunal Jhunjhunwala, founder of airpay, adding there could be some moderation in October, especially among high-value merchants.

"The announcement has prompted merchants to con-



The MDR was announced on 15 September.

MINT

sider the cost of accepting higher-value UPI payments even before the new structure takes effect. There is also some confusion about which transactions will actually attract MDR," said Jhunjhunwala. As merchants gain more clarity on rules and how they apply to them, some of this initial concern may subside, he added.

October may also show a different trend. "September suggests some caution in the market, but October may be different as the new MDR structure takes effect midway through the month," Jhunjhunwala said, adding that some categories may be hit, with merchants with a larger share of over ₹2,000 transactions likely more affected.

The finance ministry has reintroduced a 0.4% MDR on

person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions of above ₹2,000, while capping the total fees at ₹300. Person-to-person (P2P) transactions, utility-bill payments, auto-debit transactions and mutual-fund subscriptions, as well as payments to small merchants receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month through UPI QR codes, have been exempt.

At an event on 24 September, NPCI chief executive Dilip Asbe said any change causes disruption but that overall transaction volumes are expected to remain steady. However, he acknowledged that reintroducing MDR after six years without charges had been "difficult" and could "create some pain", attributing the pushback from ecosystem players to misinformation on the structure of MDR charges.

"Any post-15 October dip must be evaluated in context, as UPI volumes and value naturally contract during the second half of every month. If a dip exceeds the historical 3-5% volume or 10-19% value range, it would warrant concern; otherwise, it reflects standard fluctuations," Cashfree Payments' Datta said.

Festival-season spending may support UPI transactions even after 15 October, he said.

For an extended version of the story, go to [livemint.com](#)

FROM PAGE 1

per kilometre basis, depending on contracts that run for over a decade. Electric bus operators typically procure buses from manufacturers and tie up with firms that help develop the infrastructure required to run them.

The pricing in the tender was very aggressive, "with the difference between the lowest and the second-lowest bidder being around 10% in many cases," one of the executives cited above said.

The order will allow JSW to diversify beyond captive demand for electric buses, with the company also targeting staff buses for its plants and offices as a major demand driver. In April, its foray was marked by registering 25 buses for use at a group steel plant.

JSW group's auto businesses, including CV and passenger vehicles, are privately held.

The group participated in the tender with its own fleet operator, JSW Eco Mobility, indicating it won't only make the buses but also operate them for over 10 years.

"The entry of an established industry conglomerate like JSW Group is a positive development considering their potential to make big-ticket investments. This can be seen as a progression in their foray into India's EV manufacturing space," said Shyamasis Das, who heads the electric-mobility research vertical at New Delhi-based think tank Centre for



The order will give a boost to Sajjan Jindal-owned JSW Group.

MINT

Social and Economic Progress.

JSW has kicked off its electric-bus push with an annual capacity of 10,000 units at its 90-acre unit in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, launching its buses under the Ampstar brand.

Initially planned for 3,604 e-buses, the government tender was expanded to 4,054 buses to include demand from Haryana. Other winners include PMI, which bagged 1,248 buses; green urban transport firm Sai Green Project, which won 1,236 buses; and Eka Mobility, which won 270 buses.

Software firm Inventive Software Solutions Pvt. Ltd. won 100 buses.

Eka Mobility confirmed the development in an email. JSW declined to comment. Emails to PMI, Sai Green and Inventive Software Solutions remained unan-

swered. Central government tendering agency Convergence Energy Services Ltd (CESL) did not respond to emailed queries.

The PM-eBus Sewa scheme is part of the government's push to electrify mobility and reduce dependence on imported crude oil. The shift has gained momentum as the government increasingly directs subsidies towards electric buses and trucks.

India recorded 5,356 electric bus sales in FY26, a 37% jump from the previous fiscal, as per data from the government's Vahan registration portal. India is world's third largest e-bus market by sales, according to the International Energy Agency.

These sales are propelled by the Centre's PM E-Drive and PM-eBus Sewa schemes, which together support rollout of electric bus fleets across over 100 cities in India. Under the PM E-Drive scheme, government supports the deployment of more than 14,000 e-buses across nine major cities. The PM-eBus Sewa scheme provides operational support of ₹24 per km for 12-metre buses.

Legacy companies such as Tata Motors and Ashok Leyland have not emerged as major winners in these government tenders, which have seen newer players such as Eka Mobility and PMI Electro dominate with about two-thirds of the share in more than 20,000 electric buses tendered in the past one year.

[ayaan.kartik@livemint.com](#)



T20: WHEN CLUB OR COUNTRY TURNS INTO A GOOGLY

The original fault lines was club or country. It's increasingly becoming club in home country or club in foreign country.

howindialives.com
feedback@livemint.com

It's hard to keep English cricketer Ben Stokes out of the game. Or, the news. Three months after his shock retirement from international cricket, Stokes is at the forefront of a debate that has happened before—and will happen again, and again, in the years to come. In a cricketing landscape that is seeing the march of club cricket dust out and redraw all kinds of boundaries, Stokes is the current lightning rod of the tradeoff between club and country, self-interest and national interest.

After walking away from international cricket, the 35-year-old is keen to hit the relatively more lucrative stops of T20 club cricket. First up is Australia, in December and January. Here, Stokes has signed a contract worth, at current exchange rates, reportedly about ₹3.3 crore for 10-13 matches. This is about a third of what he is believed to have last made playing for England round the year, across many countries.

Next up, according to *The Guardian*, Stokes is lining up T20 leagues in Pakistan and the US. But the English cricket board might not give him a no-objection certificate (NOC). Stokes needs this NOC as he is contracted to an English county, Durham. The Pakistan and US leagues operate in a window that overlaps with the English domestic season, and the board doesn't want to let go off a prime draw like Stokes. It fears that giving Stokes an NOC would set a precedent—more English players will selectively abandon English county cricket for global T20 leagues that effectively pay more.

The NOC is English cricket's power play, a lever to control its players. But with a marquee name like Stokes, it can't be as blunt as the Indian board, which simply doesn't allow Indian players to play in other T20 leagues till they have retired from the national team and the Indian Premier League (IPL). The English cricket board is yet to decide on Stokes' participation in the other T20 leagues.

The last word on the Australian cricket board's plan to bite the bullet and start privatizing teams in its T20 franchise league remains. If it goes through with that plan, announced last month, it would be the last of the four major cricket countries to do so, the other three being India, Australia and England. That plan has divided stakeholders, resulting in the resignation of the Cricket Australia (CA) chair on 28 September.

The string that joins these disparate conflicts, stances and responses is the state of flux cricket finds itself in. Private money is chasing club-based T20 cricket. The Indian cricketing board acted first, with the IPL. The past three years have seen other boards take to private capital, albeit reluctantly, to stay relevant. Their response is opening many fault lines—between boards of different countries, between a board and its state affiliates, between a board and its players.

BOARD VS BOARD

National cricket boards, to whom players are affiliated, sit atop the superstructure of their T20 leagues. For all their independence, there is a hierarchy even among them. The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) controls Indian cricket, but it also wields a sizeable influence on world cricket. In 2008, it was the first to embrace club-based T20 leagues, with the IPL. Australia followed in 2011, with the Big Bash League (BBL).

But the difference in scale is massive. A



Former England Test cricket captain Ben Stokes, after retiring from international cricket, is lining up to play in T20 leagues in Pakistan and the US, which overlap with the English domestic cricket season.

REUTERS

good measure is the broadcasting deal, the main revenue component of T20 franchise leagues. The current media deal for just the IPL fetches the BCCI about ₹9,678 crore per year. The current annual CA deal for the Big Bash League, as well as for all international matches played in Australia, is ₹1,470 crore.

That naturally influences player salaries. For the 2026 season, each IPL team had a total player budget of ₹146 crore, against about ₹21 crore in the BBL. Similar differentials exist between the IPL and The Hundred (a 100-ball format) in England and the SA20 in South Africa.

This also gets reflected in the financial position of the respective cricket boards—and shapes their choices. The Indian board is a profit machine, the other three boards live hand to mouth. In 2024-25, the BCCI's revenues amounted to 1.7 times that of the boards of England, Australia and South Africa combined.

Cricket Australia can do little about its financial gap with the BCCI, or of the BBL with the IPL. But increasingly, in the T20 league context, it is compelled to think about its distance to England and South Africa. That's because these two countries have privatized teams in their short-format leagues—South Africa in 2023 and England in 2025. That privatization led to a windfall for the boards, with the English one receiving about 520 million pounds (about ₹5,700 crore).

Player salaries increased. In The Hundred, the budget for each men's team

increased from 1 million pounds in 2023 to 2.05 million pounds (about ₹26 crore) in 2026. Similarly, SA20 had a team budget of ₹21 crore in 2025—almost the same as in the BBL.

In a podcast interview earlier this year, Australian cricket captain Pat Cummins spoke about the "tension point" among Australian players in turning down the opportunity to play in The Hundred and instead playing two tests against Bangladesh in August 2026.

If players could choose leagues and followed the money, they could well opt for leagues other than that of their own country. Cummins himself has not played in the BBL since 2019, but has played in five seasons in the IPL thereafter. One reason is the BBL season runs almost concurrently with Australia's home season for test matches.

Cummins earns about \$AUS 3 million (about ₹20 crore) from CA. This is part of the current deal, where CA shares about 27.5% of its revenues with Australian players contracted at various levels. But there's unrest brewing in a shifting cricketing landscape. The feeling among Australian players is they could be earning more, especially as they are seeing peers from South Africa and England, or even full free agents, do so. This can lead to Australian players making choices that are awkward for CA.

BOARD VS STATE AFFILIATES

In this backdrop, CA said it would privatize one BBL team. That process began in September, with a call for expressions of interest to buy 100% in the Melbourne Renegades. As in England and South Africa, such a move would give CA more funds to distribute among players and inject into the sport. A private owner could also lift the team's finances and profile. But not every stakeholder is on board. In India, cricket governance is centralized, and state associations toe the BCCI line. In Australia, state associations have a voice. Two of the six state associations, New South Wales and Queensland, have rejected privatization. New South Wales was also the home association of CA chair Mike Baird, who resigned on 28 September. These two state associations argue that private owners will prioritize profits over re-investing into local pathways and community cricket. While they recognize the need for more finances, they feel this can be raised even in the current structure.

Unlike Australia, England had an easier time with their county affiliates. In The Hundred, the English board sold 49% of the eight teams to private investors via a bidding process. That resulted in a combined valuation of the eight teams of about £975 million (about ₹10,700 crore)—about 32% less than what just one team in the IPL, Rajasthan Royals, was sold for this May. It transferred the remaining 51% to the eight counties, some of whom sold additional stakes.

South Africa is structured along the



₹9,678 CRORE

Annual broadcasting revenue earned by the Board of Control for Cricket in India just from Indian Premier League matches.

₹1,470 CRORE

Cricket Australia's yearly take from the Big Bash League and international matches played in Australia.

₹146 CRORE

The total player budget of each IPL team for the 2026 season, against about ₹21 crore in the BBL.

same lines as the IPL, with a 100% franchise model for its six teams. This approach transferred the financial risk to private backers while securing upfront expansion fees.

This financial strengthening of the English and South African cricket boards in this manner plays into the BCCI's hands. All six teams in SA20, and four of the eight teams in The Hundred, trace their ownership to IPL teams. Given the leverage the BCCI has over them in the IPL, it also implicitly gives the BCCI some influence over other leagues, especially in the context of how the leagues evolve and compete against each other.

BOARDS VS PLAYERS

In all this churn, the BCCI is sitting pretty. Because of India's vast consumer market, cricket's appeal and media landscape, the BCCI does not need external capital to keep the IPL thriving. It uses that unfettered power in ways that can be seen as self-serving at best and monopolistic at worst.

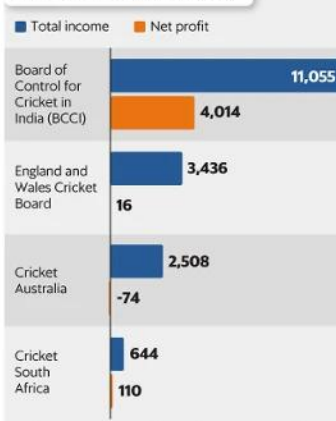
Take player participation. It does not allow Indian male players from participating in overseas T20 leagues till they retire from international cricket and the IPL. This May, 35-year-old Vijay Shankar did just that, prompting the BCCI to weigh changes. At the same time, with its considerable financial and soft power, the BCCI draws overseas players. Some other countries have player associations, notably England and Australia, and they have negotiated concessions from their boards to play in the IPL.

Cricketers today are earning signifi-

Global impact

BCCI wields a sizeable influence on world cricket

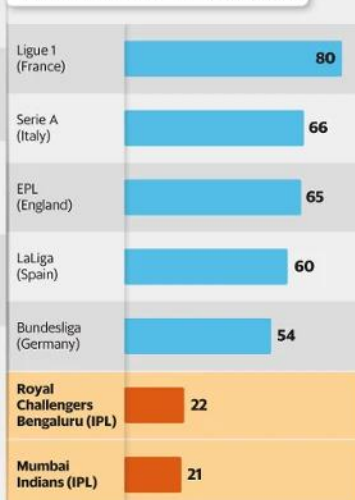
2024-25 financials (in ₹ crore)



All four boards have different financial years: India from April to March, England from February to January, South Africa from May to April, and Australia from July to June. Figures for other boards converted to Rs crore at the average exchange rate for the period.

Source: Annual reports of respective boards

Wage-to-revenue ratio in 2024-25 (%)



Source: Deloitte Annual Review of Football Finance 2026; annual reports

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT



Shubman Gill earned ₹11.5 crore over 71 match days playing for India in 2025 and ₹17.6 crore from the IPL's Gujarat Titans over 15 playing days.

PTI



Liked this story?
Share it by
scanning the
QR code.

Stokes), or become free agents and play in any T20 league (Alex Hales and Jason Roy of England, or Trent Boult of New Zealand).

Boards don't allow players a complete freedom of choice, especially the BCCI. Thus, from a player's perspective, they are not maximizing the earning potential of a finite career. For example, both Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma currently only play the IPL for two months and the occasional one-day matches for India. They could easily slot the BBL or The Hundred into their schedules for more gametime and earnings.

The same is the case with other Indian players, who have no option but to abide by the BCCI's hierarchy of IPL, national cricket and domestic cricket.

Compared to their counterparts in other professional sports, IPL teams spend a smaller portion of their revenues on player salaries. In the five main European football leagues, for example, total player salaries amounted to 54-80% of combined club revenues. In 2024-25, for both Mumbai Indians and Royal Challengers Bengaluru, this was 21-22%.

Players are watching. The opportunities in T20 leagues are multiplying, though none is as lucrative as the IPL. The overlap in team ownership between the IPL and other leagues might also lead to a clamour from owners to allow Indian players to play in those leagues. The advent of T20 leagues changed world cricket. A lot more could still change.

howindialives.com is a search engine for public data



OUR VIEW



Why Gandhi's talisman should remain resonant

In 1947, he urged decision-makers to ask whether the poorest and weakest would benefit. The test didn't just survive India's pursuit of rapid economic growth, it's especially salient today

"will give you a talisman," Mahatma Gandhi offered in a handwritten note shortly before India achieved freedom in 1947, "Whenever you are in doubt, or when the self becomes too much with you, apply the following test. Recall the face of the poorest and the weakest man whom you may have seen, and ask yourself if the step you contemplate is going to be of any use to him. Will he gain anything by it? Will it restore him to control over his own life and destiny? In other words, will it lead to *swaraj* for the hungry and spiritually starving millions?" Back then, 'talisman' conveyed a sort of north star for guidance, 'man' was gender-neutral and the Hindi term '*swaraj*' meant one's own liberty as much as national self-rule. The basic test that Gandhi set, however, retains both its clarity and vitality. Indeed, it ought to resonate across generations, regardless of how large India's economy grows.

For four-and-a-half decades, it was largely interpreted as a socialist filter. It may well have nudged India to adopt a 'mixed economy,' as proposed by the Bombay Plan of 1944 drafted by J.R.D. Tata, G.D. Birla and other leading industrialists. Even the country's policy remix of 1991 was broadly justified as a path out of mass deprivation. "We need to expand the scope and the area for the operation of market forces," Manmohan Singh noted in his 1991 budget speech, arguing that while price-system reforms would improve resource allocation, state intervention must focus on the needs of those on "the edges of a subsistence economy." Without wealth creation, Singh added, we would not be able to end "abject poverty, ignorance and disease." He wanted wealth harnessed in harmony with equity and justice to end poverty and serve everyone, for which he

said Gandhi's philosophy of trusteeship "should be our guiding star." Since 2014, relief for the hard-up has been a major policy theme of the Narendra Modi government too, with many welfare outlays expanded. That a larger economic pie means more money for national goals is now an axiom. The only way to tackle poverty, Modi said in his 15 August address of 2018, was "through the empowerment of poor people." This was a shift in emphasis away from entitlements, but in consonance with Gandhi's advice.

Over the past 25 years, India has seen a sharp drop in extreme poverty. Yet, as the country prospers, how badly Indian multitudes have been left behind by prosperity—at least in relative terms—looks more stark than ever. This lends Gandhi's test a renewed urgency. Signs of a 'K-shaped' economy persist long past the covid shock, with the well-off wealthier but vast numbers more or less stuck where they are. Such a split in upward mobility could spell premature market saturation, which may dampen investment in productive capacity, constrain India's overall access to capital and leave us in a 'middle-income trap.' Intimations of it, evident in some sectors already, cannot be brushed aside. If quality-of-life aspirations slump in the face of real-world hardships, the harder it will be to break above a GDP-per-head level that can fund a state apparatus designed to secure equitable health and education for all. Had this been an earnest priority right from the start, India's post-1947 emergence may have dodged the risk of that trap, arguably. But it is never too late to plug the gaps that may get in the way of our goals. This exercise must take inequities into account that economic theory tends to ignore. Even a flicker of doubt over the country's path should make us recall the poorest and weakest.

MY VIEW | FARM TRUTHS

El Niño has spelt a twin whammy for the country's rural economy

Deficient rainfall threatens not just food security but also rural incomes. India must relieve distress



HIMANSHU

is associate professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University and visiting fellow at the Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi.

The monsoon season technically ended on 30 September. As expected, it was affected by the El Niño phenomenon, which typically leads to deficient rainfall in the Indian subcontinent. While final figures are yet to be released, our cumulative rainfall deficit until 29 September was 13%, marginally higher than during the 2014 drought. More than the aggregate, what matters is the geographical distribution of rainfall. This reveals a much larger deficiency of 25% in east India and the southern peninsula. The least deficit is in central India (just 3%) and then in north-west India (6%). However, there is large variation within central India, with some vulnerable areas such as Marathwada (-39%), Vidarbha (-27%) and Saurashtra (-23%) affected badly. North-west India is generally an irrigated area and thus less impacted by insufficient rains during the monsoon season. However, both eastern India and the southern peninsula include large parts that are primarily rain-fed, and weak rainfall impacts these areas proportionately more. For example, Bihar (-32%), Assam (-40%), Rayalaseema (-40%) and the interior regions of Karnataka (-31%) are likely to witness a significant impact on agricultural production. Within large states too, the rainfall deficiency is not uniform, with some parts receiving excess rain and others largely deficient. For example,

although Bihar has an overall 31% deficiency, 66% of its districts reported deficient rainfall. As for other states, 97% of Karnataka's, 64% of Maharashtra's, 82% of Tamil Nadu's and 68% of Gujarat's districts reported deficient rainfall.

It is hard to predict the precise impact on agricultural output, given India's diverse agro-climatic zones and varied cropping patterns. Any optimism over this year's sowing coverage, at 110.8 million hectares, is largely misplaced. Sowing data in India can hardly serve as an indicator of agri-health, given the preponderance of small and tiny farm holdings. The predominance of subsistence farming also means that farmers don't leave their land fallow despite deficient rains. Leaving it fallow is a luxury that few can afford. Deficient rainfall, however, does show up in cropping-pattern changes and the yields of crops sown. While yield data will only be available after the harvest, sowing numbers suggest a decline in rice acreage by 1.7 million tonnes, with a shift towards pulses and coarse cereals.

However, an inference can be drawn from past experience, particularly of recent years. In 2014, when India's rainfall deficiency was last at 12%, its impact on gross value added (GVA) was not significant, with agricultural GVA increasing by 1.2%. The index of agricul-

tural production, however, saw a sharp 4.5% decline. Rice, the primary *kharif* crop, witnessed only a 1% output decline but the overall output of cereals in that agricultural year, including *rabi* crops, was down 4.5%, along with pulses and foodgrain output, which fell 4.9%, the most after 2009-10. It wasn't rice but wheat that witnessed a big decline in 2014; its output dropped 9.7%, which pulled down overall cereal production.

This year is likely to be similar, with *rabi* crops also likely to get affected; water reservoirs have been impacted and El Niño is expected to strengthen in the coming months. By latest estimates, India's reservoir levels are lower than normal and below last year's.

Any assessment must, therefore, also account for these likely production losses. The rising cost of fertilizers has already led to decline in fertilizer use. Along with rising energy prices, Indian farmers face a double whammy of declining farm production and profitability.

The issue is no longer whether agriculture will witness lower output and lower yields, but the extent of it nationally and its regional spread. Since this year's rainfall deficiency has been greater in many rain-fed areas and other zones known for low agricultural productivity, the impact will not be limited to agricultural income compression. International agencies such as the United Nations World Food Programme have predicted a 22% global rise in the severity of acute hunger.

While India may be relatively insulated, thanks to publicly held cereal stocks, a threat to food security cannot be ignored. At the same time, supply shocks will create inflationary pressures that make it all the more difficult for the poor and vulnerable to buy staples. At a time when India's rural economy is already under stress due to rising input costs (mainly energy and fertilizers), the priority should be to protect the rural economy from the twin threats of food insecurity and income compression.

QUICK READ

This year's 13% rainfall deficiency has hurt farm output, just as a 2014 shortfall did. Uneven rains across the country left some regions worse off than others, multiplying harvest risks.

It helps that India has high food stocks but households may still find staples going out of reach. Rising prices and weak farm earnings constitute a twin shock that policy must address.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

I adhere to my doctrine of trusteeship in spite of the ridicule that has been poured upon it. It is true that it is difficult to reach. So is non-violence. But we made up our minds in 1920 to negotiate that steep ascent. We have found it worth the effort.

MAHATMA GANDHI

MY VIEW | MUSING MACRO

How the Tata legacy evokes Gandhi's idea of trusteeship

AJIT RANADE



is senior fellow with Pune International Centre

Gandhi's birth anniversary this year is an appropriate occasion to examine his idea of trusteeship. The dispute involving Tata Trusts and Tata Sons has made it a live question: how can a business preserve a social purpose across generations, especially when those entrusted with it disagree?

Mahatma Gandhi accepted that talent and enterprise could create wealth and livelihoods. But what did ownership entitle a person to do with that wealth? In 1939, he wrote: "The rest of my wealth belongs to the community and must be used for the welfare of the community." By "the rest," he meant what remained after an honourable livelihood. That wealth would be held with owners who must act as custodians and trustees for society.

Trust is at the heart of economic life. Workers place their safety and livelihoods in the hands of an employer. Customers rely on its products and entrust it with their money and data. Communities provide land, water,

public infrastructure and the stability that helps businesses grow. None of these contributions appears fully in a company's financial figures. In addition, unborn generations inherit the effects of decisions made today. As enlightened corporate citizens, companies are expected to take these effects into account. Such companies earn an implicit licence to operate, with society's unspoken consent renewed by their conduct.

The Tata Group provides a rare example of an ownership structure built around public purpose. Philanthropic trusts hold 66% of Tata Sons, the group's holding company. The Trusts draw on wealth created by successful businesses to support education, health and other causes. Those businesses, in turn, must remain competitive and well run if the Trusts are to sustain their work. Tata philanthropy stretches back more than a century; the Trusts' commanding stake in Tata Sons gives that commitment an institutional form. This seems like a working model of Gandhi's idea.

That model is now under strain, with disagreements over leadership and a possible public listing on the stock market. There are legal questions, regulatory requirements and rights of shareholders to consider, none of which can be waved away by invoking the

Tata legacy. Equally, the value of an ownership structure dedicated to philanthropy cannot be solely measured by the prevailing market price. Hence, this dispute deserves a resolution that respects both sound business governance and the purpose for which the Trusts exist. The Tata inheritance belongs to the public in a moral sense, alongside the legal rights of its owners and the duties of its directors. This is a test of whether those rights and duties can work together with the Group's philanthropic mission.

Other arrangements are possible that reflect the spirit of Gandhi's trusteeship idea. Azim Premji committed substantial wealth from his own holding in Wipro to philanthropy while keeping philanthropic institutions apart from control of the company. The Tata Trusts combine philanthropy with decisive ownership at the apex. Both approaches can serve society.

The Tata approach requires especially clear rules on who makes busi-

ness decisions, who holds decision-makers accountable and how the Trusts fulfil their charitable duties.

Gandhi's idea also reaches inside the firm. A company may fund hospitals while also exposing workers to avoidable danger, paying small suppliers late or damaging local water sources. India's corporate social responsibility law directs qualifying firms to spend 2% of their average net profits on social causes; much useful work may result from this. But expenditure after profits are earned cannot by itself tell us how responsibly those profits were earned.

Is trusteeship too dependent on the goodwill of owners? Gandhi understood the difficulty. He called absolute trusteeship "an abstraction like Euclid's definition of a point," yet thought it worth striving for. He also recognized the need for public pressure and regulation. His economics has a clear foundation in human dignity, restraint and the welfare of others, even if it does not supply a

complete rulebook for a modern corporation.

That foundation is a good guide for decision-making. Boards can hold leaders answerable for worker safety, fair treatment of suppliers and environmental harm, alongside financial performance. Communities affected by large projects can get a real hearing. Trust deeds, board rules and succession plans can protect a public purpose if a widely respected leader is no longer around to reconcile disagreements.

Classical economics has much to say about how markets organize production and exchange. Marxian economics asks who owns the means of production and who gets the gains. Gandhi asked what obligations follow from the power to own and produce. Human dignity, restraint and the welfare of others were part of this Gandhian economics. These questions can arise under private ownership, worker ownership and state ownership alike.

Gandhi wrote: "A trustee has no heir but the public." The Tata dispute shows how difficult it can be to safeguard that principle through changing times. Its lesson for other businesses is to ask, while building wealth, whose trust makes that wealth possible—and how that trust will be preserved among those who come after us.



Destinations that offer luxury on a platter



Looking for staycation options for the weekend? Some properties that offer a lot of room for indulgence and Insta-worthy images

Team Lounge

A relaxed, luxurious getaway doesn't always have to mean heading to the hills or the beach. There are several properties across the country that offer a quieter way to travel, from heritage estates and palaces to retreats surrounded by nature. Many of these properties go beyond plush rooms and attentive service, offering a sense of place through architecture, local cuisine, history and curated experiences. They make a strong case for slowing down and exploring a region at a more leisurely pace. We've curated a list of luxury properties that combine beautiful settings, thoughtful hospitality and a sense of quiet luxury, making them ideal for a laidback escape.

RAJASTHAN

Set along the Jodhpur-Jaisalmer highway, about 1.5 hours from Jodhpur airport, Kaner Retreat is an intimate 10-room resort spread across seven acres of the Thar desert. Opened in 2022, the retreat offers a quieter take on Rajasthan, with experiences rooted in the landscape and local culture. Its signature Kaner Clay Experience, launched last year in October, combines a walkthrough of its Thar Desert Pottery Exhibition with a seven-course



(Clockwise from top) Kaner Retreat offers intimate breakfasts or dinners on the dunes; a Rajasthani thali; and Glenburn Penthouse captures the old-world charm of Kolkata.

lunch by chef Pankaj Sharma of Udaipur's famous fine-dining restaurant Syah. Culinary experiences are woven into the Kaner's other activities too: an Oran, or sacred grove, walk ends with a Rajasthani *thali*, while a jeep safari culminates in an intimate dinner on the dunes. For those who prefer their Rajasthan with a little more pulse, The Johri puts you in the heart of Jaipur's bustle. A 19th-century home, long known as Lal Haveli, Johri has been restored to offer travellers the best of both the worlds, past and present. Each of the five suites, the common areas and the restaurant have been designed by New York-based designer Naina Shah to bring together traditional and modern aesthetics. The hotel has a carefully curated collection of antique and custom furniture, textiles and art

from Rajasthan. Its restaurant focuses more on seasonal, farm-fresh produce. There's also a cocktail bar, a daily "high-chai" afternoon tea service, option of getting Ayurvedic massages, and complimentary yoga and meditation sessions. **MADHYA PRADESH** The Oberoi Rajgarh Palace in Khajuraho is a restored 350-year-old palace set across 76 acres, with a natural lake, Sal and Palash forests and views of the Vindhya ranges. Originally built by a maharaja of the Bundela dynasty, the palace is less than 15 minutes from the Panna National Park and Tiger Reserve and a short drive from the Khajuraho Group of Monuments. The estate has 65 rooms and suites, including private pool villas, while its dining options span royal Bundelkhandi recipes and



international cuisines. Sajin the Forest is another option in Madhya Pradesh if you are looking for a destination that offers relaxation as well as fun. Inspired by the elements of nature, the resort, close to the Pench National Park, has three categories of rooms named after tree species: Mahua (large rooms for big groups), Palash (for small families) and Sal (suites built side by side). The walls of the resort depict the traditional Gond Art. You can also enjoy a jungle safari, a backwater safari, learn pottery, and have dinner under the stars.

DELHI

Anvaya, a six-suite luxury retreat, is a hidden gem of Delhi. Located in the Chhattarpur area, the property is like an oasis hidden near a forest while being only 20 minutes away from the heart of the Capital. Private butlers, a pool, a kitchen that serves global cuisines with a focus on seasonality—it serves luxury, comfort and everything in between.

WEST BENGAL

Less than an hour from the international airport, the nine-suite Glenburn Penthouse offers a base in the heart of Kolkata, with views of landmarks such as the Victoria Memorial and Howrah Bridge. The property, filled with antique furniture, art and vintage tableware, is close to the Maidan and Park Street, making it easy to explore the city's restaurants and cultural attractions. Its in-house menus draw on Bengali and Anglo-Indian cooking as well as Kolkata's street-food culture.

ODISHA

Set on the banks of Chilika Lake, Rambha Palace in the Ganjam district offers a glimpse of Odisha's royal heritage and hospitality. The 200-year-old pink palace retains its old-world character, with an 18th-century billiard table, French chandeliers, antique furniture and Venetian lime-plastered walls. Local craftsmanship is woven into the interiors too, from Dhokra figurines to furnishings, giving the 16-suite property a strong sense of place while offering guests a taste of life in a former royal residence. You can also sample local Odia cuisine, including a variety of seafood dishes.

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com



By the women artisans of Porgai Artisans Association.

For the weekend Of romance and Oktoberfest

A Mint guide to what's happening in and around the city

DELHI

MASTERS IN MAKING—THREADS OF CONTINUUM: REWEAVING THE FUTURE OF HERITAGE

Till 4 October
Curated by Anjchita B. Nair, the exhibition brings together 20 artists, artisans, craft-led brands and collectives engaging with textile traditions through contemporary practice. Participants include Jagrity Phukan, who explores *muga*, *eri* and mulberry silk traditions of the Brahmaputra Valley, and the Porgai Artisans Association, a collective of 80 women artisans from Tamil Nadu's Sittilingi Valley. The collective presents Lambadi embroidery, a tradition revived from near-extinction in 2000s. **11am-7pm. Alliance Française, Galerie Romain Rolland, Lodhi Estate.**

PROST AT RICK'S

Till 4 October
Celebrate Munich's Oktoberfest with a Bavarian-inspired cuisine, along with a wide range of international beers. The menu includes Potato Pancake Bites with sour cream and chives, Chicken Schnitzel Bites with creamy mustard aioli, Currywurst with curried tomato sauce and crispy fries, and Apfelstrudel with vanilla ice cream. **5pm-12.45am. Rick's, Taj Mahal, Man Singh Road.**



BENGALURU

BAREFOOT IN THE PARK

3 October
Directed by Sridhar Ramanathan and Shubham Srivastava, this two-hour play is based on Neil Simon's much-loved Broadway classic. It follows the early days of a marriage, turning the adjustments and disagreements into an entertaining mix of romance and chaos. **3pm/6.30pm. Bangalore International Centre, 4th Main Rd, 2 Stage, Domlur. For details, visit in.bookmyshow.com**

MUMBAI

KAB SE BAITHE: DREAM NOTE LIVE

2 October
Enjoy an evening of Hindi songs with pop-rock influences by Jaipur-based indie-pop duo Dream Note, comprising singer-songwriter Gaurav Tiwari and guitarist and music producer Taresh Agarwal. **8pm. The Studio Theatre, Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre, Bandra. For details, visit www.nmacc.com**

Inside the global market for elite \$30,000 sheepdogs

Britain's border collies are attracting buyers who see them as indispensable workers, not pampered pets

Bloomberg

Del set off at a tear, turning on a dime as he corralled three sheep around the field. His white socks and the flash of white across his nose were nothing but a blur. Nearby, his trainer stood with a whistle between his pursed lips. The 5-year-old border collie stopped, sank low to the ground and waited. On cue, he took off again. This ballet between sheepdog and flock continued for a few minutes in front of the roughly 200 people who'd gathered on a mild July morning in Skipton, a town near Leeds in northern England. Several dozen others watched via webcam. Then the bidding began. Over the past three decades, Skipton's Craven Cattle Mart (CCM) has grown into an international hub for some of the world's best working sheepdogs. Some of them end up in the US and Europe, even as far as Japan. Dogs sold here have fetched as much as \$30,000, putting them among the most

expensive sheepdogs ever sold. Among the pickup trucks and farm vehicles in the parking lot were high-end SUVs adorned with personalized license plates. Most of those in the crowd appeared to be locals. But watching from the edge of the field was Toru Takei, who, among the work boots and fleece vests, stood out in his Los Angeles Dodgers cap and sneakers. Takei had read about the Skipton sheepdog sales from his home in Japan, where he farms 23 sheep as a hobby and has a keen interest in herding competitions known as sheepdog trials, a sport that's taking off abroad. He already has two—one from the Netherlands and another from Wales, where he had plans to visit during his trip to the UK. "There are less dogs in Japan. I have no selection," Takei says. He hopes to buy another one day, this time from Skipton, but today, he's just here to watch. Border collies have been bred for generations to herd sheep, their natural instincts moulded further by trainers and farmers to respond to voice commands or a whistle. They're sold as puppies or fully trained, or "broken." Unsung to outsiders, sheepdogs are vitally important to operations of commercial farms, and adored by devout trialists, some of whom travel the world competing. On 20 September, thousands of spectators and competitors from 34 coun-



tries converged on Scotland for "the biggest World Trial ever," according to the president of the International Sheep Dog Society. Christine Ryder, who manages about a thousand sheep and a herd of cows with her husband at their farm in nearby Blubberhouses, tells the signs of a good worker: "Their ears are up, and they're watching everything. They're ready to go. If a sheep turns and starts coming towards it, if they turn and run away, well, that's no good to anybody." Skipton has long been synonymous

with sheep farming. References to a "sheep town" on this site date as early as the 11th century. It sits at the southern edge of the Yorkshire Dales National Park, with valleys and moors carved into fields by drystone walls stretching for miles to the north. A charter granted by King John in 1204 first allowed Skipton to start a market selling sheep and wool. The town's importance as a market hub grew when the Leeds & Liverpool Canal was built during the Industrial Revolution more than 500 years later. The first official Skipton auction took place in 1886 not far

from the town centre, on the site of what's now a grocery store. Today, CCM sits just outside of town. It's become a place farmers go not only to buy and sell but also to socialize. The sheepdog sales, with their record-setting prices and international clientele, now attract many who simply come out to watch. A good sheepdog is often more useful than a human employee, able to cover huge distances quickly. It's part of why some buyers will travel so far to buy one. Some dogs can also work cattle. And while drones and robots have been touted for more than a decade as potential replacements for sheepdogs, sheep grow used to and start to ignore drones. CCM started sheepdog sales in 1996. At that time there were only a couple of other places selling dogs in Britain. In those early days, many sold at auction were "rejects," says Eaton, the auctioneer, meaning surplus to a farm's needs rather than quality. But shepherds and trialists who trained dogs saw an opportunity to start intentionally breeding, finding and training the sheepdogs, specifically for the auctions. "It opened up almost a new cottage industry," Eaton says. Interest grew in lockstep with the quality of the dogs on offer, particularly among sheepdog trialists who were competing at an international level for their countries. Over the next two decades, Skipton

grew into a premier sheepdog trading destination, and the dogs themselves became headline-making luxury investments. These days, CCM runs several sheepdog sales a year. Some are entirely online, such as the one on 23 September, where trainers uploaded recorded videos of their dogs. Over the past 12 months, multiple dogs sold online have made five figures, heading to southern England, Ireland and the south of France. They can have resale value too: A 5-year-old dog previously bought by a now-retired shepherd was sold to an anonymous buyer in Germany for £4,200. American Samantha Furman got her first border collie 30 years ago. At the time, she had planned to become an accountant. But she started doing lessons with a highly regarded handler, for whom she ended up working for several years. Then she got a few sheep of her own to train her dogs with and became part of the then-fledgling US sheepdog trial circuit, which has since boomed in popularity. Farming followed. "Somewhere in there, I really just got pretty passionate about the sheep and wanted to do the best I could," says Furman, who lives appropriately enough in Farmville, Virginia. She now has a flock of 600. Write to us at feedback@livemint.com